



Global Standard
GLUTEN-FREE
ISSUE 4



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**Global Standard
GLUTEN-FREE
ISSUE 4**

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How this publication is organised

This publication sets out the requirements for the auditing and certification of food manufacturers in order for them to achieve certification for the Global Standard Gluten-Free.

The document consists of the following parts:

Part I Introduction

Provides an introduction and background to the development and benefits of the Standard.

Part II Requirements

Details the requirements of the Standard with which a company must comply in order to gain certification.

Part III Audit protocol

Provides information on the audit process and rules for the awarding of certificates. It details the different audit programmes available within the Standard, as well as information on the logos and the BRCGS Directory.

Part IV Management and governance

Describes the management and governance systems in place for the Standard and for the management of certification bodies registered to operate the scheme.

Appendices

The appendices provide other useful information, including auditor competency requirements, product categories and a glossary of terms.

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Part I

Introduction

Welcome to Issue 4 of the Global Standard Gluten-Free (hereafter referred to as the Standard), formerly known as the Gluten-Free Certification Program. Originally developed and published in 2012, the Standard has been updated at regular intervals since to reflect best practice, and to encourage adoption of the Standard worldwide. The Standard provides a framework for manufacturers to assist them in the production of gluten-free products which comply with legal requirements globally, and to meet customers' requirements.

Certification against the Standard is recognised globally by many retailers, coeliac associations, food service companies, procurement companies, and manufacturers when assessing the capabilities of their suppliers.

The Standard has been developed to promote a systems approach to prevent gluten contamination or failures that could harm the public. Correctly applied, a site's gluten-free management system will provide a robust level of protection from failure, and if failure does occur, it will enable the rapid identification and management of risks and deviations.

The format and content of the Standard is designed to allow an assessment of a company's premises, operational systems and procedures by a competent third party – the certification body – against the requirements of the Standard.

What's new for Issue 4?

The development of Issue 4 followed a wide consultation to understand stakeholders' requirements and a review of emerging issues in the food industry.

The information has been developed and reviewed by working groups made up of international stakeholders representing food manufacturers, retailers, coeliac associations, certification bodies and independent technical experts.

The focus of attention for this issue has been on:

- Providing greater assurance to our stakeholders by adding grading of non-conformities thereby ensuring the site meets the requirements of the Standard.
- Strengthening of the Standard by adding a section on labelling and pack control to ensure this aspect of the process is more robustly controlled.
- Creating a new optional section of clauses to integrate the AO ECS-specific requirements to meet EU legislation and be eligible to use the Association of European Coeliac Societies (AO ECS) Crossed Grain Trademark on pre-packaged foods.
- Extending the scope to include management of outsourced processing.
- Encouraging clarity of understanding and reporting by splitting the requirements into smaller, more manageable clauses.
- Simplifying the Schedule A process for sites and certification bodies.
- Introducing the option of using information communication technology (ICT) and remote auditing.
- Removing two Appendices from the Standard, making them into standalone guidance documents which will be subject to periodic review.
- Incorporating the Issue 3 position statements into the Standard.
- Adding colour-coding of requirements to show the activities that would usually be audited as part of the assessment of the production areas and facilities, and those that would form part of an audit of records, systems, and documentation.
- Using terminology which is consistent with other BRCGS standards.

The requirements of Issue 4 represent an evolution from previous issues, with a continued emphasis on management commitment, a robust gluten-free management system, and a supporting food safety programme (based on hazard analysis and critical control points (HACCP)). The continuing objective has been to drive up standards of compliance with the requirements and implementation of good manufacturing practices.

The Association of European Coeliac Societies (AOECS)

An important new element of this issue of the Standard is the inclusion of an additional set of specific requirements in Part II, section 8 of the Standard which are mandatory for those sites that produce gluten-free products or ingredients to be commercialised bearing the Crossed Grain Trademark on pre-packaged food. Brands sourcing from those sites will need to enter into a licence agreement with the relevant AOECS member society.

In the framework of the collaboration agreement existing between AOECS and BRCGS, AOECS has reviewed the Global Standard Gluten-Free and has concluded that sections 1 to 7 are consistent with the AOECS Standard for Gluten-free Foods. However, there are specific AOECS requirements needed to enter the European market and obtain the AOECS Crossed Grain Trademark to use on pre-packaged food. These requirements have therefore been incorporated into Part II, section 8 of this issue of the Standard.

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The AOECS is an umbrella organisation of over 40 AOECS member societies inside and outside of Europe. It is the owner of the AOECS Standard for Gluten-Free Foods and the Gluten Free Alliance which serves to promote the use of the Crossed Grain Trademark on gluten-free pre-packaged food products.

The Crossed Grain Trademark has been used for over 50 years to enhance the clear and reliable identification of gluten-free pre-packaged food products which meet the AOECS Standard for Gluten-free Foods or recognised equivalent standard.

Food products which have been manufactured at sites certificated to the Global Standard Gluten-Free and have been audited against the requirements in Part II, section 8 of the Standard, can now display the Crossed Grain Trademark on printed packaging materials. The related brand must also possess a signed, valid License Contract with the AOECS member society in the country in which the brand is based.

The Global Standard Gluten-Free Site Programme Agreement

Prior to a site's first audit against the requirements of the Standard, the company shall enter into a Site Programme Agreement with BRCGS. This document outlines the terms and conditions of certification to the Standard and the fee structure associated with certification to the Standard. Further information on the Site Programme Agreement can be found in Part III, section 1.

Audits

There are a number of audit options available for sites and these have expanded for Issue 4.

Due to the added confidence provided by unannounced audits, the Global Food Safety Initiative (GFSI) benchmark introduced a requirement for all certificated sites to have at least one unannounced audit within every 3-year period, even where they have opted to be part of the announced audit programme. Therefore, every 3 years where the Global Standard Gluten-Free audit is combined with a GFSI benchmarked scheme audit, the audit will be

unannounced. The certification body will notify the site and agree which year this will be, to ensure that the site is aware that an unannounced audit will take place in the coming year. However, the actual date of the unannounced audit will not be communicated to the site in advance.

More information on the audit options available for sites is available in Part III of the Standard.

GFSI certification requirement

All sites who wish to gain certification to the Standard shall also be certificated in one of the following:

- a GFSI benchmarked food safety scheme
- BRCGS Global Standard START! at the Intermediate level of certification; or
- an equivalent to BRCGS Global Standard START! at the Intermediate level of certification offered by a GFSI-benchmarked certification programme owner.

All sites shall continue to establish and maintain the environmental and operational programmes (prerequisite programmes) necessary to create an environment suitable to produce safe and legal products. In addition, all sites shall conduct a complete hazard analysis, based on Codex HACCP principles, for all their processes and products in order to identify and control all hazards effectively.

The scope of the Standard

The Standard sets out the requirements for the manufacture, processing and packing of:

- processed foods, both own brand and customer-branded
- ingredients for use by food service companies, catering companies and/or food manufacturers
- pet foods*
- cosmetics*
- natural health products*.

* Pet foods and cosmetics are not eligible for use of the AOECs Crossed Grain Trademark. Natural health products will need further clarification from the relevant AOECs member society.

The certification status only applies to the management systems of the manufacturing site where the audit has taken place. Products manufactured are not “certified” gluten free. The gluten-free status of the product is maintained via gluten control methods implemented at the certificated site and verified via laboratory testing.

The AOECs’s specific requirements for use of the Crossed Grain Trademark are detailed in Part II, section 8 of the Standard. These requirements are mandatory to comply with for sites that want to access the European market and commercialise their products using the Crossed Grain Trademark on the food packaging. These requirements can only be included in the audit where the site can provide specific evidence to the certification body. Please refer to Part III, section 4 for more information.

The Standard shall not apply to activities relating to the wholesale, importation, distribution or storage of food products that are outside the direct control of the company. BRCGS has developed several standards setting out the requirements for a wide range of activities undertaken in the production, packaging, storage and distribution of food. Appendix 1 provides further details of the scopes of, and relationship between, the current BRCGS standards.

Principles of the Standard

A business must have a full understanding of the products it produces, manufactures and distributes, and have systems in place to identify and control gluten to ensure product safety and legality. The Standard is based on five key components:

- senior management commitment
- the implementation of a food safety plan – a HACCP-based hazard and risk assessment system (which provides a step-by-step approach to managing food safety risks)
- the establishment of prerequisite programmes
- a robust gluten-free management system
- product control.

Senior management commitment

Within a business certificated to the Standard, gluten control must be seen as a cross-functional responsibility that draws on many departments, using different skills and levels of management expertise across the organisation. Effective gluten control extends beyond technical departments and involves commitment from production operations, engineering, distribution management, raw materials procurement, customer feedback and human resources (who organise and procure activities such as training).

The starting point for an effective gluten-free management system is the commitment of senior management to the development of an all-embracing policy to guide the activities that collectively ensure the effective control of gluten. The Standard places a high priority on clear evidence of senior management commitment.

The requirements for senior management commitment are given in Part II, section 1.

A HACCP-based system (the food safety plan)

A HACCP-based system focuses on the significant food safety hazards related to products and processes that require specific controls to ensure the safety of individual food products or lines.

The Standard requires the development of an overarching food safety plan incorporating all the Codex Alimentarius HACCP principles. Such a plan requires the input of all relevant departments and must be supported by senior management.

The requirements for a HACCP-based food safety plan are given in Part II, section 2.

Prerequisite programmes

These are the basic environmental and operational conditions in a food business that are necessary to produce safe food. They control the generic hazards covering good manufacturing and good hygienic practice, as detailed in Part II, section 2.

The gluten-free management system

The intention of the Standard is to enable sites to control gluten at every step of their operation - from supplier approval right through to the finished product. There are specific elements in the requirements which detail the organisational and management policies and procedures which form the gluten-free management system. This provides a framework by which a site will meet the requirements in this Standard. These requirements are given in Part II, section 3.

Product control

This section covers the requirements relating to product development (including formulation changes), labelling, marketing claims and control of contamination from gluten. It provides details of the organisational and management policies and procedures that provide a framework by which an organisation will achieve the requirements in this Standard. These requirements are given in Part II, section 4.

Position statements

During the lifetime of a published standard, the BRCGS technical advisory committee (TAC) may be asked to review the wording of a clause or provide an interpretation of a requirement or a detail of the protocol. The decision made by the TAC is known as a position statement. Position statements are binding on the way that the audit and certification process is carried out and are an extension of the Standard.

Further details are available in Part III, section 5.2, and Appendix 8.

Documented procedures

In many instances, the Standard specifically states that the requirements shall be satisfied by documented procedures, processes or records; in other instances, documentation is implied. Further clarification is provided in the glossary definitions in Appendix 9 (e.g. 'procedure', which clearly states that documents are required in these situations). The company needs to be able to demonstrate that systems are in place, working consistently, and that documents are available for reference when required. Therefore, any policies and documents must be written in sufficient detail to satisfy their purpose and must reflect the activities that happen in practice. These documents can be hard copy (i.e. paper-based) or electronic.

The certification process

In this scheme, food businesses are certificated upon completion of a satisfactory audit by an auditor employed by an independent third party – the certification body.

For a business to receive a valid certificate on completion of a satisfactory audit, the organisation must select a certification body approved by BRCGS. BRCGS lays down detailed requirements which a certification body must satisfy in order to gain approval and operates a comprehensive certification integrity programme to ensure high standards are maintained. A list of approved certification bodies is available in the **BRCGS Directory**.

Benefits of the Standard

The Standard is endorsed by, or recognised by, coeliac associations in Canada, the USA, Mexico and Latin America. The Standard is also recognised by coeliac associations in Europe provided Part II, section 8 is included in the scope of the audit. As a result, global organisations encourage the adoption of the Standard as a means of effective gluten control, strengthening gluten-free claims and meeting regulations worldwide.

Adoption and use of the Standard, along with certification, provides a number of benefits to businesses and their customers. These include:

- an internationally recognised standard that provides a report and certification which can be accepted by customers in place of their own audits, thus reducing time and cost
- the option for certificated companies to appear in the publicly available section of the BRCGS Directory, providing recognition of their achievements and use of a logo for marketing purposes
- access to several, consumer-recognised trademarks for use on product packaging, allowing brand owners to demonstrate their commitment to the Standard while increasing the availability and variety of gluten-free products in the marketplace
- a comprehensive scope, covering product safety and legality
- a single standard and protocol that govern an audit by third-party certification bodies, allowing a credible, independent assessment of a company's gluten-free management system
- enabling companies to ensure that their suppliers are following good gluten control practices
- the completion of corrective actions, root cause analysis and preventive actions on any non-conformities to the Standard, and within the site's product safety and gluten-free management systems; this reduces the need for customers to follow up audit reports, and demonstrates continual improvement

- a range of audit options, including combined, standalone, announced, unannounced and blended audit programmes, to satisfy customer demands and enable companies to demonstrate compliance through a process which best suits their operation and the maturity of their systems.

Independent research carried out by the University of Birkbeck, London, has demonstrated that businesses with BRCGS certification demonstrate greater compliance with national regulations and are subject to less intervention. Additional research demonstrates that certification to BRCGS standards generates extensive and positive business impacts for businesses in relation to growth, profitability, operational efficiency and innovation.

Guidance and training

BRCGS produces a range of guidance documents, training courses and a self-assessment tool designed to assist sites with the application of the Standard and an understanding of the core skills needed, such as risk assessment and root cause analysis. Further information about BRCGS training can be found on the **BRCGS website**.

BRCGS guidance covers a range of topics including (but not limited to):

- an interpretation guideline for Issue 4 which explains every requirement of the Standard
- product changeover (i.e. good practices when moving from the production of one product to another)
- effective internal audits
- vulnerability assessments
- production risk zones
- category-specific guidance for the red meat and poultry sectors.

Sites certificated to any one of four BRCGS Standards (Agents & Brokers, Food, Packaging Materials, Storage & Distribution) can download BRCGS publications from Participate as part of their service package. For details, see Appendix 10.

Effective date of Issue 4

As with all revisions of BRCGS standards, there must be a transition period between publication and full implementation. This allows time for the retraining of all auditors and allows manufacturers to prepare for the new issue of the Standard. Therefore, certification against Issue 4 will commence on 5 August 2024. All certificates issued for audits started prior to this date will be against Issue 3 and be valid for the period specified on the certificate.

Acknowledgements

BRCGS wishes to acknowledge all those key stakeholders and industry experts who have contributed to the preparation of Issue 4 of the Standard or provided invaluable feedback through the consultation process. All those who participated in the working groups are listed in Appendix 11.

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Part II

Requirements

How the requirements are set out

Most sections of the Standard are broken down into smaller subsections. Each subsection has a title indicating the subject of the content in the tables beneath the title. Below the headers in the tables are more specific and detailed requirements (clauses) that, if applied appropriately, will help to achieve the stated objective of the requirement.

Colour-coding of requirements

Production processes represent the key activities on site. The audit process therefore gives specific emphasis to the practical implementation of gluten control procedures within the site and general good manufacturing practices. Auditing these areas forms a significant proportion of the audit (around 50% of the audit time is spent auditing production and site facilities, interviewing staff, observing processes, and reviewing documentation in production areas with the relevant staff). Production areas include factory production, storage, dispatch, engineering, on-site laboratory facilities and external areas.

As an aid to this process, the requirements within the Standard have been colour-coded. Colour-coding shows the activities that would usually be audited as part of the assessment of the production areas and facilities, and those that would form part of an audit of records, systems, and documentation.

Key to colour-coding of requirements

Audit of records, systems and documentation		
Audit of production facilities and good manufacturing practice		
Requirements assessed in both		

Additional requirements

Global Food Safety Initiative certification requirement

To be eligible for certification against the Standard, all sites shall also be certified in one of the following:

- a Global Food Safety Initiative (GFSI) benchmarked scheme
- BRCGS Global Standard START! to Intermediate level of certification
- an equivalent programme offered by a GFSI benchmarked certification programme owner.

AOECS-specific requirements for access to the European market and use of the Crossed Grain Trademark

The requirements in sections 1–7 of the Standard shall be applied to all operations. Any food business operator wishing to use the Crossed Grain Trademark shall also meet the requirements in section 8.

The requirements of section 8 are mandatory if sites:

- produce products within the scope of the AOECS Standard for Gluten-free Foods
- can prove that they are, or intend to be, a Crossed Grain Trademark licence holder, or commercialise their products to actual or potential licence holders (e.g. by providing a letter of intent).

1 Senior management commitment

1.1 Commitment to the gluten-free management system

Clause	Requirements
1.1.1	The site shall have a policy that confirms: - the senior management's full support for developing, implementing, continuously improving and maintaining an effective gluten-free management system - the site's commitment to producing gluten-free products in conformity with all requirements of the Standard. The policy shall be signed and dated by a representative of the senior management at the site with authority to ensure adherence to responsibilities described in this section. The policy shall be: - renewed on an annual basis - renewed if the senior management representative is replaced - communicated to all staff.
1.1.2	The site's senior management shall demonstrate a commitment to the gluten-free management system by: - providing the necessary resources and the time required for the development, implementation, and effective maintenance of the gluten-free management system and for the training of appropriate staff in their area(s) of responsibility - providing the financial resources to ensure that the construction of the premises, its internal fittings, the installation of the equipment, the maintenance of the premises and equipment, as well as the supplies required to perform the above, meet all applicable regulatory and programme requirements and support the implementation and effectiveness of the gluten-free management system - designating personnel with defined responsibilities and the authority to initiate, implement, and record corrective actions - communicating to employees the importance of meeting the requirements of the site's gluten-free management system, including any regulatory requirements related to product safety and gluten control, and the importance of reporting problems to the identified person(s) - designating personnel with authority to enforce conformity of the product safety procedures identified in the site's gluten-free management system for any person entering or working within the site - providing sufficient time for gluten-free management system team meetings - fostering the continuous improvement of the gluten-free management system to ensure its effectiveness. As a guide, this may include the following, although this is not an exhaustive list: - verification of control measures - making changes to the system as a result of corrective actions or reassessment activities - ensuring active participation in gluten-free management system team meetings.

Clause	Requirements
1.1.3	The site shall have a genuine, original hard copy or electronic version of the current Standard available and be aware of any changes to the Standard or protocol that are published on the BRCGS website.
1.1.4	Where the site is certificated to the Standard, it shall ensure that recertification audits occur on or before the audit due date indicated on the certificate.

1.2 The gluten-free management system team leader

Clause	Requirements
1.2.1	Senior management shall appoint a gluten-free management system team leader who, irrespective of other responsibilities, shall have the responsibility and authority to: • ensure that the gluten-free management system is developed, validated, periodically reviewed, implemented, continuously improved and maintained • be the main contact with designated staff and auditors. It shall be clearly documented who deputises in the absence of the gluten-free management system team leader.
1.2.2	The gluten-free management system team leader shall have an in-depth knowledge of, and show competence in, the site's gluten-free management system principles.
1.2.3	The gluten-free management system team leader shall have taken and passed the BRCGS Global Standard Gluten-Free (Issue 4) Sites Training course.

1.3 The gluten-free management system team

Clause	Requirements
1.3.1	The gluten-free management system team shall be multidisciplinary and shall include those responsible for quality/technical, procurement, product development, sanitation and hygiene, production operations, engineering/maintenance, and other relevant functions.
1.3.2	The gluten-free management system team members shall have specific knowledge of gluten controls and relevant knowledge of product, process, marketing claims, relevant legislation and associated hazards.
1.3.3	Where the site does not have the appropriate in-house knowledge of gluten controls, external expertise may be used. However, the day-to-day management of the gluten-free management system shall remain the responsibility of the site.

1.4 Gluten-free management system team meetings

Clause	Requirements
1.4.1	The gluten-free management system team shall meet at appropriately planned intervals, annually at a minimum, to discuss, among other points: • action plans and timeframes from previous gluten-free management system team meeting reviews • changes in the gluten-free management system • results of internal, second party, and/or third-party gluten-free management system audits • customer complaints and results of any customer feedback • incidents (including both recalls and withdrawals), corrective actions, out-of-specification results, and non-conforming materials • reviews of the effectiveness of the gluten-free management system • resource requirements. The frequency of meetings shall be sufficient to manage the risks associated with the topics covered and may be increased depending on circumstances. As a guide, these may include the following, although this is not an exhaustive list: • new product development • following a significant product safety incident (e.g. a product recall) • emergence of a new risk (e.g. known adulteration of an ingredient, risk to supply chain due to climate-affected harvest, or other relevant, published information, such as the recall of a similar product) • change in raw materials or supplier of raw materials • change in ingredients/recipe • change in processing conditions, cleaning and disinfection procedures, process flow or equipment. Records of the meeting shall be documented and used to encourage continuous improvement. The decisions and actions agreed within the review process shall be effectively communicated to appropriate staff (including senior management), and actions implemented within agreed timescales.
1.4.2	A member of the senior management team shall attend, at a minimum, one gluten-free management system team meeting annually.
1.4.3	The site shall have a reporting system which enables issues relating to the gluten-free management system to be brought to the attention of senior management.

2 The food safety plan - HACCP

2.1 The food safety plan - HACCP principles

Clause		Requirements
2.1.1		The site shall have a fully implemented and effective food safety plan based on Codex Alimentarius HACCP principles which specifically considers gluten as a hazard.
2.1.2		All relevant information needed to conduct the preliminary steps, the hazard analysis, and the determination of the CCPs and process controls shall be documented, updated whenever there are changes, and included within the development and reviews of the gluten-free management system.

2.2 Prerequisite programmes

Clause		Requirements
2.2.1		The site shall establish and maintain environmental and operational programmes (prerequisite programmes) which control the risk from gluten. As a guide these may include the following, although this is not an exhaustive list: • premises • purchasing • transportation, receiving, shipping, and storage • equipment and maintenance • personnel and training • sanitation • pest control • traceability, recall, and withdrawal • allergen controls. The control measures and monitoring procedures for the prerequisite programmes must be clearly documented and included within the development and reviews of the gluten-free management system.

2.3 Gluten-free management system maintenance and reassessment

Clause	Requirements
2.3.1	The gluten-free management system team shall review the system at least annually and prior to any changes that may affect product safety (gluten specifically). As a guide this may include the following, although this is not an exhaustive list: • change in gluten-free materials or in a supplier of gluten-free materials • change in ingredients/recipe • change in processing conditions, process flow, or equipment • change in packaging, storage, or distribution conditions • emergence of a new risk (e.g. known adulteration of an ingredient or other relevant, published information, such as a recall of a similar product) • changes required following a recall or withdrawal • new developments in scientific and/or regulatory information associated with ingredients, process, or product • non-conformities identified during monitoring and verification activities • consumer/client complaints • non-conformities identified during Global Standard Gluten-Free audits or surveys done by government agencies or the national, regulatory competent authority • changes in production volume that impact on the product flow, sanitation schedule, employee training, etc.. Appropriate changes resulting from the review shall be incorporated into the gluten-free management system, communicated through relevant training, fully documented, and the validation recorded.

3 The gluten-free management system

3.1 Document control

Clause	Requirements
3.1.1	The site shall operate an effective document control system to ensure that only the correct versions of documents, including recording forms, are available and in use.
3.1.2	The site shall have a procedure to manage documents that form part of the gluten-free management system. This shall include: • a list of all controlled documents, indicating the latest version number • the method for the identification and authorisation of controlled documents • a record of the reason for any changes or amendments to documents • the system for the replacement of existing documents when these are updated. Where documents are stored in electronic form these shall also be: • stored securely (e.g. authorised access, control of amendments, password protected) • backed up to prevent loss.

3.2 Records

Clause	Requirements
3.2.1	The company's management shall ensure all information and documentation is accessible during evaluation processes and subsequent verification/audit activities.
3.2.2	Records shall be established to document: • the monitoring results, including, when necessary, the recording of quantifiable values as prescribed in the gluten control measures • all information and actions taken in response to a deviation identified as a result of monitoring and verification • the verification results. Records shall be kept to demonstrate the effective application of gluten control measures.

3.3 Internal audits

Clause	Requirements
3.3.1	The scheduled programme of internal audits shall include: • the gluten-free management system, including the activities to implement the system (e.g. supplier approval, corrective actions, and verification) • prerequisite programmes • procedures implemented to achieve the requirements of the Standard. The frequency at which each activity is audited within the scheduled programme shall be established in relation to the risks associated with the activity and previous audit performance. All activities shall be covered at least annually. Each internal audit within the programme shall have a defined scope and consider a defined activity or section of the gluten-free management system.
3.3.2	Internal audits shall be carried out by appropriately trained, competent auditors. Auditors shall be independent (i.e., they shall not audit their own work).
3.3.3	The internal audit programme shall be fully implemented. Internal audit reports shall identify conformity as well as non-conformity and include objective evidence of the findings. The results shall be reported to the personnel responsible for the activity audited. Corrective actions, preventive actions, and timescales for their implementation shall be agreed and their completion verified.

3.4 Supplier approval, purchasing, and incoming ingredients and inputs

Clause	Requirements
3.4.1	Procedures and policies related to purchasing of ingredients and inputs shall be developed and implemented to ensure: • proper control and identification of gluten • that any analytical method chosen to verify the gluten-free status of ingredients and inputs shall have a demonstrated fitness for purpose.
3.4.2	The site shall undertake a documented risk assessment of all ingredients and inputs to identify potential gluten sources (including hidden gluten sources of contamination). The risk assessment shall form the basis for the gluten-free ingredients and inputs acceptance as well as for the testing procedure and processes adopted for supplier approval and monitoring.

Clause	Requirements
3.4.3	The risk assessment for gluten-free ingredients and inputs shall be current and shall be updated, at a minimum, when: • there is a change in gluten-free ingredient or input processing • there is a change in the supplier of the gluten-free ingredient or input • a new risk of gluten contamination emerges • there is a product recall or withdrawal in which a specific gluten-free ingredient or input is implicated.
3.4.4	The site shall have a documented supplier approval procedure to ensure that all suppliers and emergency suppliers of ingredients and inputs effectively manage gluten contamination risks and are operating effective traceability processes. The approval shall be based on risk, and shall include, at a minimum: • a valid certificate to show that the site conforms to the BRCGS Global Standard Gluten-Free. The scope of the certification shall include the ingredient or input purchased. Or • a supplier audit, with a scope to include gluten control. The audit report shall be reviewed and verified by a demonstrably competent member of the gluten-free management system team. The supplier audit shall be undertaken by an experienced and demonstrably competent auditor. Where the supplier audit is completed by a second or third party, the company shall be able to: • demonstrate the competency of the auditor • confirm that the scope of the audit meets the requirements of this clause • obtain and review a copy of the full audit report. Or all of the following • A supplier questionnaire, with a scope to include gluten control, that has been reviewed and verified by a demonstrably competent person and member of the gluten-free management system team. • An allergen questionnaire to include questions about gluten content and identifies the gluten status of each ingredient or input. • The supplier's specification for each ingredient, ingredient blend, and components of ingredient blends (as applicable), clearly listing each ingredient and, where applicable, components of ingredients. Specifications shall be reviewed and agreed on by a member of the gluten-free management system team. • Documentation (e.g. letter of guarantee) indicating that the supplier shall: • meet the site's specifications • notify the site when a change is made to their ingredient blend formula • confirm that such changes will not be made without prior approval from the site.
3.4.5	The site shall have an up-to-date, documented list of approved suppliers of gluten-free ingredients and inputs. The list shall be readily available to relevant staff (e.g. at goods receipt).

Clause	Requirements
3.4.6	The site shall have a procedure for the acceptance of incoming ingredients and inputs on receipt, based upon the risk assessment. As a guide this may include the following, although this is not an exhaustive list: • sampling and testing • visual inspection on receipt • certificates of analysis for gluten from an accredited laboratory – specific to each consignment • certificates of analysis for gluten, from suppliers that have used an approved method (as per the BRCGS Guideline on Sampling and Testing for Gluten) that has been validated in-house. Validation shall include participation in a proficiency testing programme, through an accredited proficiency test provider. • checks to ensure that the labels of approved ingredients and inputs received match the site's ingredient and input specifications • any other means necessary to satisfy the risk assessment. A list of incoming ingredients and inputs and the requirements to be met for acceptance shall be available. The parameters for acceptance and frequency of testing shall be clearly defined, implemented, and reviewed.
3.4.7	Procedures shall be in place to ensure that approved changes to ingredients and inputs, or of suppliers, are communicated to goods receipt personnel. Only the correct version of the ingredient and inputs shall be accepted and released into production.

3.5 Management of outsourced processing

Clause	Requirements
3.5.1	Where any processes are outsourced, including production, manufacture, processing or storage, the risks associated with gluten shall form part of the site's food safety plan (HACCP plan).
3.5.2	The approval process for outsourced processing shall include a review of procedures to prevent contamination by materials containing gluten. Records of the review shall be kept.
3.5.3	The company shall be able to demonstrate that: • the outsourced processor is certificated to the BRCGS Global Standard Gluten-Free Or • a supplier audit has been undertaken within the last 12 months, with a scope that includes the applicable requirements of the BRCGS Global Standard Gluten-Free. Where this supplier audit is completed by a second or third party, the company shall be able to: • demonstrate the competency of the auditor • obtain and review a copy of the full audit report.

Clause	Requirements
3.5.4	The company shall establish inspection and test procedures for products where part of the processing has been outsourced, including visual and/or gluten testing. The frequency and methods of inspection or testing shall depend on risk assessment.

3.6 Finished product specifications

Clause	Requirements
3.6.1	Documented, accurate and up-to-date specifications shall be available for all gluten-free finished products. They shall include key data to meet customer and legal requirements and assist the user in the safe usage of the product.

3.7 Complaint handling

Clause	Requirements
3.7.1	Complaints relating to gluten-free products, where an alleged adverse reaction has been reported, shall be recorded and investigated. Corrective and preventive actions appropriate to the seriousness and frequency of the problems identified shall be carried out promptly and effectively by appropriately trained staff. The results of the investigation and subsequent corrective and preventive actions shall be recorded.
3.7.2	The site shall notify the certification body issuing the current certificate for the site against this Standard and BRCGS once a substantiated complaint about a gluten-free product indicates it has a high probability of failing to comply with the requirements of the Standard. Notification to BRCGS shall be via email to brcgs.integrity@lgcgroup.com

3.8 Product recall and withdrawal

Clause	Requirements
3.8.1	The site shall notify the national, regulatory competent authority, certification body, and BRCGS of any recalls or withdrawals related to a gluten-free product. Notification to BRCGS shall be within 24 hours from the date of release of the official recall or withdrawal notice. Notification to BRCGS shall be via email to brcgs.integrity@lgcgroup.com The company shall then provide sufficient information to enable the certification body to assess any effects of the incident on the ongoing validity of the current certificate within 21 calendar days. As a minimum, this shall include corrective action, root cause analysis and a preventive action plan.
3.8.2	The effectiveness of the recall procedures and traceability system shall be tested on one gluten-free product at least annually.

3.9 Validation of gluten control measures

Clause	Requirements
3.9.1	Gluten control measures shall be validated. Where the control of gluten is achieved through prerequisite programmes or control measures other than critical control points, this shall be stated and the adequacy of the programme to control gluten validated. Validation documentation shall include, but are not limited to: • scientific, technical, or regulatory support to prove effective control of gluten • supporting data to demonstrate that the monitoring procedures are effective enough to detect loss of control at a control point before the finished product leaves the site.

4 Product control

4.1 Product development

Clause	Requirements
4.1.1	Procedures and policies shall be developed and implemented to ensure adequate control of new or modified product formulations. These shall include, at a minimum: • a product development and approval process flow, including steps to be followed when modifications to existing product formulations are made • communication links among all the steps in the chain of production once a new formulation or changes in a formulation have been approved • a requirement for the product development and approval process to include review and agreement by the gluten-free management system team leader.

4.2 Approval and control of labels

Clause	Requirements
4.2.1	Procedures shall be developed and implemented to ensure effective control of new or modified labels. These shall include, at a minimum: • a label approval process that includes steps to be followed in case of re-approval of product labels following modifications to existing product formulations • the documentation of the communication links between all the steps in the chain of production following approval of a new label or changes to a label • evidence of physical comparison of received labels to approved labels • confirmation that labels printed internally or externally meet agreed specifications.
4.2.2	Procedures related to labelling of finished product shall be developed and implemented to ensure that the product label accurately represents the product name and the composition of the product on which the label is affixed. Where the label information is the responsibility of a customer or a nominated third party the company shall provide information: • to enable the label to be accurately created • whenever a change occurs which may affect the label information.

4.3 Marketing claims

Clause	Requirements
4.3.1	The gluten content of finished products shall comply with the legislation of the country in which they are sold.

Clause	Requirements
4.3.2	Use of BRCGS-managed trademarks on finished product packaging shall be: • formally approved by BRCGS, by way of receipt of a signed Trademark Approval Form prior to use • in compliance with the BRCGS Free-From Trademark Guideline and/or the requirements of the owner of the trademark or statement • in compliance with the legislation of the country where the product will be sold.
4.3.3	There shall not be any reference to “product certification” on packaging, advertising, marketing, nor any other form of communication materials where BRCGS-managed trademarks are used. Claims referring to “certification” shall be limited to the site, or the gluten-free management system delivered there.

4.4 Contamination control

Clause	Requirements
4.4.1	Procedures shall be developed and implemented to control substitutions and cross-contamination from sources of gluten in the products. Such procedures shall include, as appropriate: • production scheduling if dedicated lines for gluten sources are not available • the introduction of gluten by movement of personnel • the traffic patterns of employees who handle gluten sources • the traffic flow and handling during the receiving, storage, processing, and packaging of ingredients containing gluten sources • dedicated uniforms and personal protective equipment for employees handling gluten sources • dedicated or segregated storage of ingredients containing gluten sources • the identification and sanitation of bulk containers housing a gluten source or ingredients containing gluten sources • dedicated utensils, equipment, and areas used to handle gluten sources • the handling and storage of rework product(s) containing ingredients that are gluten sources • the use of equipment, tools, and utensils with sound sanitary design • the cleaning of equipment/product contact surfaces/areas during operations if dedicated lines/equipment/areas for gluten sources are not available • dedicated maintenance and engineering tools • appropriate airflow • the control and separation of ingredients that are used in both gluten-free and gluten-containing production • controls on gluten-containing foods brought onto site by staff, visitors and contractors and for catering purposes.

4.5 Product formulation and rework

Clause		Requirements
4.5.1		Procedures associated with the processing of gluten-free products shall be developed and implemented to ensure that the correct ingredient is added to the correct product as indicated in the formula.
4.5.2		Procedures related to the use of rework shall be developed and implemented to prevent the introduction of gluten into a gluten-free product. Procedures shall ensure that the rework formulation ingredients and the product formulation ingredients are compatible, including their appropriate designation (e.g. labelling).

4.6 Segregation and disposal of obsolete and waste material

Clause		Requirements
4.6.1		Procedures for the segregation and safe disposal of obsolete and waste materials shall be developed and implemented to prevent their inadvertent use or risk of cross-contamination. Obsolete and waste materials include: • labels (refers to any pre-printed packaging that bears a list of ingredients) • ingredients, inputs and work in progress • finished products.

4.7 Laboratory and testing

Clause		Requirements
4.7.1		A sampling and gluten-testing programme shall be developed, documented and implemented as part of an overall programme to validate and verify control of cross-contamination by undeclared gluten sources in ingredients and finished products. Sites shall evaluate their risk of contamination with gluten before they start developing a sampling programme for all incoming materials and for each processing step, following the BRCGS Guideline on Sampling and Testing for Gluten.
4.7.2		An accredited laboratory shall be used annually (at a minimum) to verify the site's internal testing practices. The laboratory shall have ISO 17025 accreditation from a competent authority. Methods for gluten testing shall fall within the scope of their accreditation, and the methods for the applicable matrix shall be fully validated at their site.

5 Labelling and pack control

5.1 Packing line and packing area control measures

Clause	Requirements
5.1.1	There shall be a formal process for the allocation and return of printed packaging materials intended for use on gluten-free products to packing lines. Control measures in the packing area shall ensure that only the packaging for immediate use on gluten-free products is available to the packing machines. Where offline coding or printing of packaging materials intended for use on gluten-free products occurs: • setting and amendments to the printer parameters (e.g. the input of, or changes to, date codes) shall only be completed by an authorised member of staff • controls shall be in place to ensure that only correctly printed material is available at the packing machines. Processes shall be in place to check label use is reconciled with expected use and the cause of any inconsistencies investigated.

5.2 Product changeover

Clause	Requirements
5.2.1	Documented checks of the production line shall be carried out before commencing production and following changes of product. These shall ensure that lines have been suitably cleared and are ready for production. Documented checks shall be carried out at product changes to ensure that all products and printed packaging and labels from the previous production have been removed from the line before changing to the next production.

5.3 Product label verification measures

Clause	Requirements
5.3.1	Procedures shall be in place to ensure that all gluten-free products are packed into the correct packaging and correctly labelled. These shall include checks: • at the start of packing • during the packing run (e.g. at predefined intervals and when printed packaging or labels are brought to the line during the production run) • when changing batches of packaging materials at the end of each production run. The checks shall also include verification of any printing carried out at the packing stage.

Clause	Requirements
5.3.2	Where online verification equipment (e.g. bar code scanners) is used to check product labels and printing, the site shall establish and implement procedures for the operation and testing of the equipment to ensure that the system is correctly set up and capable of alerting or rejecting product when packaging information is out of specification. At a minimum, testing of the equipment shall be completed at: • the start of the packing run • the end of the packing run • a frequency based on the site's ability to identify, hold and prevent the release of any implicated materials should the equipment fail (e.g. during the packing run or when changing batches of packaging materials). The site shall establish and implement procedures in the event of a failure in the online verification equipment (e.g. a documented and trained manual checking procedure).

6 Schedule A

6.1 Products listed

Clause	Requirements
6.1.1	Where finished products manufactured at the site display, or are developed with the intention of displaying, any of the trademarks covered by a Schedule A, these products shall be listed. The site shall have a separate Schedule A for each brand owner, with the appropriate trademark use for each product indicated. A Schedule A shall not be required where no trademarks are used.

6.2 Communication of amendments

Clause	Requirements
6.2.1	The site shall immediately communicate any of the following changes to any Schedule A to BRCGS: • cessation of production for any of its brand owners • addition or removal of products bearing a trademark • change of trademark use • change of Universal Product Code (UPC), or product identification number • change of company name or site address.

6.3 Schedule A validity

Clause	Requirements
6.3.1	The site shall possess a valid Schedule A indicating trademark use for each brand owner at the audit. Each Schedule A shall list the products displaying any of the trademarks covered by the schedule. To be considered valid, every Schedule A shall: • list the site name and current address • be an accurate reflection of trademark use • be signed and dated by BRCGS.

7 Gluten-free training

7.1 Training of personnel

Clause	Requirements
7.1.1	All personnel, including engineers, agency-supplied staff, temporary staff and contractors, shall have received general gluten-free training and be trained in the site's gluten control measures and gluten handling procedures commensurate with their role.
7.1.2	Where personnel are engaged in activities relating to gluten control measures and critical control points, relevant gluten-free training and competency assessments shall be in place.

7.2 Documented training programme

Clause	Requirements
7.2.1	The site shall have a documented gluten-free training programme in place, covering the training needs of personnel. These shall include, at a minimum: • identifying the necessary competencies for specific roles • providing training or other action to ensure staff have the necessary competencies • reviewing the effectiveness of gluten training • delivery of training in the appropriate language of trainees.

7.3 Labelling and packing process training

Clause	Requirements
7.3.1	All relevant personnel shall have received training on the site's labelling and packing processes which are designed to ensure the correct labelling and packing of gluten-free products. This includes agency-supplied staff, temporary staff and contractors.

7.4 Training records

Clause	Requirements
7.4.1	Records of all relevant gluten-free training shall be available. Where relevant gluten-free training is undertaken by agencies on behalf of the company, records of the training shall be available.

7.5 Review of staff competence

Clause	Requirements
7.5.1	The company shall routinely review the competencies of its staff. As appropriate, it shall provide relevant gluten-free training. This may be in the form of training, refresher training, coaching, mentoring or on-the-job experience.

8 AO ECS-specific requirements

This section contains the AO ECS-specific requirements for access to the European market and use of the Crossed Grain Trademark. The Crossed Grain Trademark has been used for over 50 years on food products within Europe and outside of Europe. Its purpose is to promote safe and clear identification of gluten-free food products suitable for coeliacs and people with other gluten issues. The technical requirements for bearing the Crossed Grain Trademark on gluten free foods are defined in the AO ECS Standard for Gluten-free Foods which is an integral part of the license contract of AO ECS members with licence holders of the Crossed Grain Trademark.

AO ECS is the umbrella organisation of 38 member societies in Europe and has several affiliated members outside Europe.

The AO ECS Standard for Gluten-free Foods is in accordance with the Codex standard 118-1979 (Adoption: 1979, Amendments: 1983 and 2015, Revision: 2008). Therefore, the Crossed Grain Trademark is only permitted for foods complying with the Codex definition of gluten-free foods and EU Regulation 828/ 2014.

The Crossed Grain Trademark is registered, and its intellectual property is managed in a harmonised approach with AO ECS and its members.

Prior to a BRCGS Global Standard Gluten-Free audit incorporating the AO ECS-specific requirements, the current or potential licence holder must contact the AO ECS member society, to coordinate the necessary steps to obtain or maintain a valid Crossed Grain Trademark licence. In countries where there is no **AO ECS member society**, they will contact AO ECS at helpdesk@aoecs.org.

The auditor must confirm in the audit report that a Crossed Grain Trademark licence has been applied for or is in place between the AO ECS member society and the licence holder. In cases where the site is a different legal entity than the licence holder, the auditor needs to provide evidence in the audit report that there is an agreement in place between the licence holder and the site, and there is evidence of a Crossed Grain Trademark licence. An AO ECS licence holder may use several food business operators which may also produce for more than one Crossed Grain trademark licence holder.

The auditor must confirm in the audit report the list of Registered Products is consistent with current products to which the Crossed Grain Trademark is applied.

Certain product categories listed in Appendix 5 are not permitted to use the Crossed Grain Trademark. Only food products complying with definitions within the AO ECS Standard for Gluten-free Foods are permitted to bear the Crossed Grain Trademark. For further information please go to the **AO ECS website**.

The clauses below outline the specific requirements that must be met in order to be compliant.

8.1 Supplier approval, purchasing, and incoming ingredients and inputs

Clause	Requirements
8.1.1	Use of ingredients either gluten-free by nature or which have been rendered gluten free must be in accordance with 2.1 of the AOECs Standard for Gluten-free Foods. The R5 ELISA method (Mendez method) must be used to confirm that the gluten level does not exceed 20 mg/kg based on the food as sold or distributed to the consumer. (See clause 3.4)

8.2 Product recall and withdrawal

Clause	Requirements
8.2.1	The food business operator using or intending to use the Crossed Grain Trademark on their product(s), has a recall procedure to notify any recall and withdrawals to the AOECs member within 24 hours from the date of release of the official recall or withdrawal notice. (See clause 3.8.)

8.3 Approval and control of labels

Clause	Requirements
8.3.1	Food labels must comply with the AOECs Standard for Gluten-free Foods. - Foods as defined without any oats shall be labelled "gluten-free". The registration number shall be clearly displayed underneath the Crossed Grain Trademark and consist of the ISO country code – licence number – product number. - Foods containing oats, shall be labelled "gluten-free". However, the word "OATS" (and in the local language, if agreed by the AOECs member society) shall be clearly displayed underneath the Crossed Grain Trademark before the registration number. - Foods may be accompanied by additional statements 'suitable for people intolerant to gluten' or 'suitable for coeliacs', if permitted by national legislation. They may be labelled 'specifically formulated for people intolerant to gluten' or 'specifically formulated for coeliacs', if permitted by national legislation. (See clause 4.2)

8.4 Marketing claims

Clause	Requirements
8.4.1	Use of the Crossed Grain Trademark alongside marketing claims must comply with the AO ECS Standard for Gluten-free Foods. • Foods as defined without any oats shall be labelled “gluten-free”. The registration number shall be clearly displayed underneath the Crossed Grain Trademark and consist of the ISO country code – licence number – product number. • Foods containing oats, shall be labelled “gluten-free”. However, the word “OATS” (and in the local language, if agreed by the AO ECS member society) shall be clearly displayed underneath the Crossed Grain Trademark before the registration number. • Foods can be accompanied by additional statements ‘suitable for people intolerant to gluten’ or ‘suitable for coeliacs’. They may be labelled ‘specifically formulated for people intolerant to gluten’ or ‘specifically formulated for coeliacs’, if permitted by national legislation. (See clause 4.3)

8.5 AO ECS Crossed Grain Trademark license

Clause	Requirements
8.5.1	Only food business operators that have a valid license contract with the corresponding AO ECS member society are allowed to bear the Crossed Grain Trademark on their product(s).

8.6 Laboratory and testing

Clause	Requirements
8.6.1	The R5-sandwich-ELISA (Mendez Method) or R5-competitive-ELISA for fermented or partially hydrolysed gluten are the only approved analytical methods for manufacturers wishing to use the Crossed Grain Trademark on their products. (See clause 4.7)

Part III

Audit protocol

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Part III

Audit protocol

Introduction

The Global Standard Gluten-Free (the Standard) provides companies with a series of options with which to be audited and certificated depending on whether the audit is to take place as a standalone audit, or combined with a GFSI-benchmarked scheme, BRCGS Global Standard START! or equivalent food safety audit offered by a GFSI-benchmarked certification programme owner. This flexible approach is in response to market demand and allows companies to choose an audit option which best suits their customers' requirements, factory operations and the maturity of their food safety systems.

The audit protocol describes how these audit processes operate and explains the rules around the audit and certification to the Standard. This is an essential element of the Standard and should be read and fully understood.

Every effort has been made to ensure that the content of the Standard is accurate at the time of publication. However, it may be subject to minor change. Any additions or amendments to this normative document will be published as 'position statements' (see section 5.2). Reference should be made to the BRCGS website, where changes will be published.

Conformance by the company to the requirements of the Standard and its suitability for the awarding and continuing retention of certification will be assessed by an independent audit company – the certification body. Audit frequency will be determined according to the number and type of non-conformities.

Figure 1 summarises the steps to be followed for all companies wishing to gain certification.

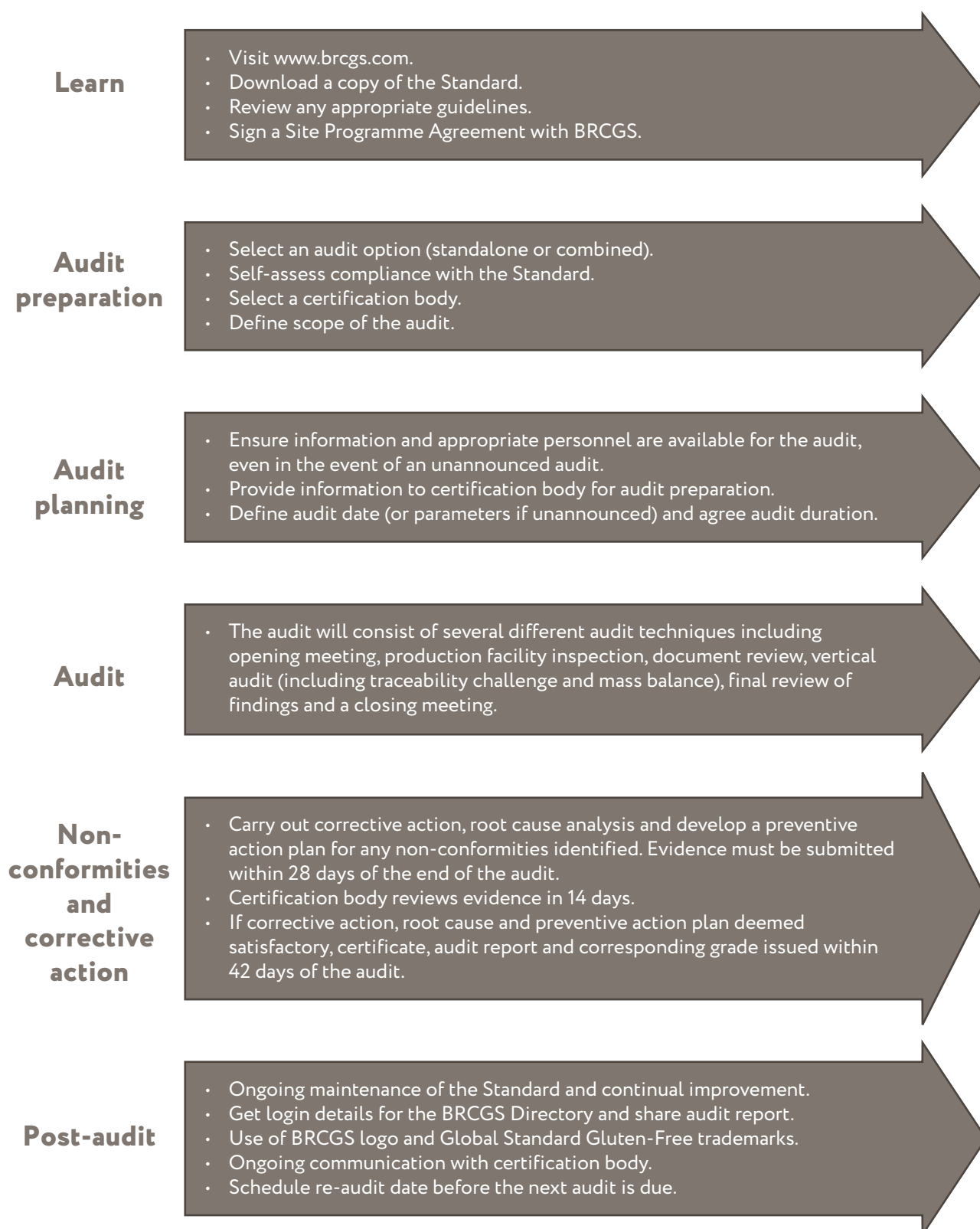


Figure 1: Audit protocol - how to gain certification

1 The Global Standard Gluten-Free onboarding process

1.1 The Site Programme Agreement

Prior to a site's first audit against the requirements of the Standard, the company shall enter into a Site Programme Agreement (previously known as a Program License Agreement) with BRCGS. This agreement outlines the terms and conditions of certification to the Standard and the fee structure associated with certification to the Standard. There are two options to complete this process:

- Complete the **Register Your Interest** form on the BRCGS website; or
- Contact the BRCGS Sales Team via email at brcgs.sales@lgcgroup.com

Payment of fees associated with the Site Programme Agreement are in addition to costs associated with the audit process and are due on an annual basis. The Site Programme Agreement will automatically renew annually unless cancelled by the site.

Sites will not be permitted to proceed to the audit with their chosen certification body until this process is completed. A Site Programme Agreement is only required to be completed once by the company for each certificated site. If a certificated site moves from the location listed on the Site Programme Agreement, a new version shall be completed, agreed and signed by a representative from the company or site.

If a company manufactures any of its own brand products at the site listed on the Site Programme Agreement, and these products use or intend to use any BRCGS-managed trademarks, a Brand Programme Agreement shall also be required.

1.2 The Brand Programme Agreement

A brand owner who chooses to use any BRCGS-managed trademarks on products manufactured at a site certificated to the Standard shall sign a Brand Programme Agreement. This agreement outlines the terms and conditions, and the fees, associated with trademark use.

A representative from the brand owner shall contact the BRCGS Sales Team via email at brcgs.sales@lgcgroup.com to enter into a Brand Programme Agreement. There are no annual fees associated with this document other than the SKU fees associated with trademark use.

All use of BRCGS-managed trademarks shall be formally approved by BRCGS via the process outlined in the Free-From Trademark Guideline.

2 General protocol – audit preparation

2.1 Selection of an audit option

There are a number of options and processes available in both standalone and combined audits for sites to demonstrate their commitment to the Standard, each of which are explained below.

2.2 Standalone audit options

The standalone Global Standard Gluten-Free (Issue 4) audit option is only available to sites who are already certificated to any GFSI-benchmarked scheme, BRCGS Global Standard START! at Intermediate level, or equivalent (to START!) food safety programme offered by a GFSI-benchmarked certification programme owner. If a site does not have any of the certifications listed above prior to their initial Global Standard Gluten-Free (Issue 4) audit, they may combine the audit with their chosen programme.

2.2.1 Announced audit

The focus of the Standalone audit is only on the Global Standard Gluten-Free requirements. This is available for existing certificated sites and those new to certification to the Standard. The audit date is agreed with the certification body in advance of the audit and all requirements of the Standard are audited within the audit visit.

2.2.2 Blended announced audit

This is available for existing certificated sites only. The blended announced audit uses information and communication technology (ICT) to remotely audit documented systems and records.

The audit is split into two separate parts: a remote audit followed by an on-site audit. The remote audit (first part) uses ICT to focus predominantly on documented systems and records, while the on-site audit (second part) focuses predominantly on gluten-free production, storage and other on-site areas.

A blended audit can only be offered by the certification body following a risk assessment which:

- confirms that a robust audit is possible (e.g. remote technology is available at the site)
- assesses the percentage of the audit that can be completed remotely.

At the time of publication, the blended audit option is available for recertification audits only and not for initial audits (i.e., the first Global Standard Gluten-Free audit at a site). Successful sites are awarded a certificate and the subsequent audit frequency is dependent on the number and type of non-conformities identified.

2.3 Combined audit options

Global Standard Gluten-Free (Issue 4) audits may be combined with any GFSI-benchmarked scheme, BRCGS Global Standard START! at Intermediate level, or equivalent (to START!) food safety audit offered by a GFSI-benchmarked certification programme owner. The combined audit options below will be determined by the type of audit programme the site has chosen for its food safety audit. The site should check with the certification body to explore the options which may be available.

2.3.1 Announced audit programme

This is available for existing certificated sites and those new to certification. For announced audits, the audit date is agreed with the certification body in advance of the audit and all requirements of the Standard are audited within the audit visit.

Depending on the type of audit programme the site has chosen for its food safety audit, there may be a requirement to have an unannounced audit periodically (for example, one unannounced audit at least every three years). The certification body will notify the site of the upcoming unannounced audit within three months of the previous audit due date. This will ensure that the site is aware that an unannounced audit will take place in the coming year. However, the actual date of the unannounced audit will not be communicated to the site in advance.

More details on audit planning can be found in section 3.

2.3.2 Blended announced audit programme

The blended announced audit programme uses ICT to remotely audit documented systems and records.

The audit is split into two separate parts: a remote audit followed by an on-site audit. The remote audit (first part) uses ICT to focus predominantly on documented systems and records, while the on-site audit (second part) focuses predominantly on production, storage and other on-site areas.

A blended audit can only be offered by the certification body following a risk assessment which:

- confirms that a robust audit is possible (e.g. remote technology is available at the site)
- assesses the percentage of the audit that can be completed remotely.

At the time of publication, the blended audit option is available for recertification audits only and not for initial audits (i.e., the first Global Standard Gluten-Free audit at a site). Successful sites are awarded a certificate and the subsequent audit frequency is dependant on the number and type of non-conformities identified.

2.3.3 Unannounced audit programme

The unannounced audit option is available to all sites and provides an opportunity to demonstrate the maturity of their quality systems. Sites which are not currently certificated need to recognise that the combined audit may not take place for up to one year from the date of application. In these cases, a site may wish to opt for a standalone audit for the first year of certification to the Standard.

The conducting of an independent, unannounced review of the production facilities, systems and procedures under this scheme provides a site's customers with added confidence in the site's ability to consistently maintain standards. This may influence the frequency of customer audits, where conducted, and other performance measures applied by the customer.

2.4 Self-assessment of compliance with the Standard

It is essential that the site is assessed against the current issue of the Standard and any current position statements, all of which are available on the BRCGS website.

The Standard should be read and understood, and a preliminary self-assessment should be conducted by the company against the Standard to prepare for the audit. Any areas that need to be improved to meet the requirements should be addressed by the company to prevent a non-conformity being raised at the audit.

Further information, guidance and training to ensure compliance with the Standard, including a downloadable self-assessment tool, are available from the BRCGS website. BRCGS also has a full range of further guidelines and supporting materials available through the website or, for certificated sites, from Participate (see Appendix 10).

An optional on-site pre-assessment may be carried out by the selected certification body in preparation for the audit to provide guidance to the site on the process of certification.

Certification bodies shall ensure that the same auditor cannot be used for both the pre-assessment and the certification audit.

Manufacturing units that are newly built or 'commissioned' shall ensure that systems and procedures in place are compliant before an initial audit is undertaken. It is at the discretion of the company when it wishes to invite a certification body to carry out an audit; however, it is unlikely that full compliance can be satisfactorily demonstrated at an audit undertaken less than three months from commencement of operation. This is likely to be the situation even where the site for certification uses quality systems developed by other certificated companies in the group. Timescales for audits shall be agreed between the site and the certification body.

2.5 Selection of a certification body

Audits against a BRCGS Standard are only recognised if these are undertaken by certification bodies that are recognised and approved by BRCGS.

BRCGS cannot advise on the selection of a specific certification body; however, they have a comprehensive programme of measurement of certification body performance around specified key performance indicators (KPIs), the results of which are converted to a 5-star rating and published with the listing of all approved certification bodies

in the BRCGS Directory. The company should ensure that its selected certification body is accepted by its customers (e.g. only 4- or 5-star-rated certification bodies may be accepted by some customers).

2.6 Company/certification body contractual arrangements

A contract shall exist between the company and the certification body, detailing the scope and category of the audit and the reporting requirements. The contract shall also contain clauses which allow the effective management of the scheme by BRCGS. These are essential to ensure confidence in the way in which the scheme is managed and consistency achieved, which benefits all certificated sites. In particular it is a condition of certification to the scheme that:

- A copy of the audit report and any subsequent certificate or audit result shall be supplied to BRCGS in the agreed format for the Standard. Other documents in relation to the audit shall be made available to BRCGS upon request. All documents submitted to BRCGS shall be copies of original documents. Documents provided will be treated as confidential.
- Where agreements are in place, BRCGS may make audit reports and certificates available to customers of sites or the authorities for earned recognition purposes. Sharing can be removed by the site at any time through the BRCGS Directory.
- The auditor(s) may be accompanied by other personnel for training, assessment or calibration purposes. This activity may include:
 - training of new auditors by the certification body
 - routine certification body shadow audit programmes
 - witness audits by BRCGS.

BRCGS reserves the right to conduct its own audit or visit to a site once certificated in response to complaints or as part of routine compliance activity to ensure the integrity of the scheme. Such visits may be announced or unannounced.

BRCGS may contact the site directly in relation to its certification status, for feedback on certification body performance or for investigation into reported issues.

This publication sets out the requirements against which sites will be audited. Contracts between the certification body and the site shall include a clause acknowledging these obligations. This contract will be formulated by the certification body.

Non-compliance with any of these contractual obligations shall be communicated to BRCGS and may result in additional compliance activities being undertaken. Non-compliance may also affect the certification status of the site.

2.7 Service fee

BRCGS requires a service fee to be collected by the certification body from the company for every audit undertaken. The certificate and audit report shall be uploaded to the BRCGS Directory but shall not be valid until the service fee and the certification body's audit fees have been received, irrespective of the outcome of the certification process.

2.8 Scope of audit

2.8.1 Defining the audit scope

The scope of the audit (products produced and manufacturing processes) shall be agreed between the site and the certification body in advance of the audit to ensure the correct allocation of an auditor (or auditors).

The audit shall include all applicable requirements within the Standard and all production processes undertaken for the products included within the scope at the site seeking certification.

The audit scope shall be clearly defined and unambiguous both on the audit report and on any certificate issued. The scope description on reports and certificates shall be based on the product scope categories listed in Appendix 5 and shall include:

- the field of audit
- the category number
- the category description.

The wording of the scope will be verified by the auditor during the site audit.

2.8.2 Exclusions from scope

The AOECs-specific requirements for use of the Crossed Grain Trademark can be excluded from the audit scope; in that situation the requirements of Part II, section 8 will not be applicable. Where excluded, this will be recorded as an exclusion from scope on the audit report and on the certificate.

The exclusion of off-site storage may also be permitted (see section 2.8.5).

No other exclusions from scope are permitted.

2.8.3 Defining the limits of a site

Audit reports and certificates are expected to be site-specific. However, in some circumstances, a company may own additional facilities or storage at more than one location, all operated under common management as a single operation, and these may be included under a single certification. This will be considered exceptional, but allowable, where all of the following conditions are met:

- All sites are under the same organisation's ownership.
- All sites operate within the same documented gluten-free management system.
- The sites manufacture product which is part of the same manufacturing process (i.e. sequential steps in the manufacture are completed at different sites).
- The sites solely supply the other sites, with no additional customers.
- The sites are no more than 30 miles/50 km apart.

All sites must be visited as part of the same audit schedule (i.e. within the same timeframe).

It must be clearly stated on the report and certificate that the audit has consisted of visits to more than one site address (e.g. the manufacture of cheese at Cheddar Industrial Estate, Wensleydale, Yorkshire, and maturation at Camembert Road, Ripon).

2.8.4 Auditing activities where the head office is located separately

When undertaking audits of sites which are part of a larger manufacturing group, it is not uncommon for some of the requirements within the scope of the Standard to be undertaken by a central or head office.

The detailed requirements for acceptance and management of such circumstances within the audit protocol are defined in Appendix 3.

2.8.5 Storage facilities – off-site

While storage facilities on the same site as the production facility shall always be included within the audit of the site, it is not uncommon for sites to also own additional off-site storage facilities. Where additional storage facilities are owned and managed by the company in the vicinity of the production site (i.e. within a radius of 50 km), these shall be identified on the audit report and either audited as part of the site audit or specifically excluded.

2.9 Auditor selection

It is the responsibility of the site to ensure that adequate and accurate information is given to the certification body, detailing the products it manufactures and the process technologies it uses, to enable the certification body to select an appropriate auditor (or audit team) with the required skills to undertake the audit.

The certification body, auditors and the site shall be aware of the need to avoid a conflict of interest when arranging for auditors to visit the site. The site may decline the services of a particular auditor offered by the certification body. The same auditor is not permitted to undertake audits on more than three consecutive occasions at the same site.

Where the audit is not being carried out by the auditor in the native language of the site, an appropriate translator shall be provided who has knowledge of the technical terms used during the audit.

3 General protocol – audit planning

This section provides general information on audit planning for the Global Standard Gluten-Free audit.

Please refer to section 4.1 for more detailed information on what is required when Part II, section 8 (AOECS-specific requirements for use of the Crossed Grain Trademark) is included in the scope of the audit.

For more detailed information on what is required for planning of the GFSI-benchmarked certification audit, BRCGS Global Standard START! Intermediate level audit, or equivalent food safety audit offered by a GFSI-benchmarked certification programme owner, please refer to the audit protocol of the relevant Standard.

3.1 Audit planning

3.1.1 Preparation by the company

For announced audits, the site shall agree a mutually convenient date, with due consideration given to the amount of work required to meet the requirements of the Standard.

There is a requirement for the site to be prepared for the audit, to have appropriate documentation for the auditor to assess and to have appropriate staff available at all times during the on-site audit.

The site shall ensure that the production programme at the time of the audit covers products for the intended scope of the certification. Where possible, the widest range of these products shall be in production for the auditor to assess. Where the product range is large or diverse, the auditor has the discretion to continue the audit until sufficiently satisfied that the intended scope of the certification has been assessed. Where a significant production process is undertaken during a different period of the year from the audit, a separate audit will be required to assess that production method.

For combined unannounced audits, the actual date of the audit will not be communicated to the site.

3.1.2 Information to be provided to the certification body for audit preparation

The site shall supply the certification body with background information prior to the audit day to ensure the auditor (or audit team) is fully prepared and to provide the best opportunity for the audit to be completed efficiently. The information will be requested by the certification body and may include but is not limited to:

- the background and structure of the company
- a summary of the site's HACCP plan (or food safety plan) and critical control points (CCPs)
- the process flow diagram
- a simple site plan

- the management organisational chart
- the list of products or product groups included within the audit scope
- a description of any special handling requirements (e.g. for allergens, claims or other certifications)
- a description of the site and building fabrication
- typical staff shift patterns
- production schedules, to allow audits to cover relevant processes (e.g. night-time manufacture or where production processes are not carried out each day or are only carried out at certain times of the day)
- an outline of any outsourced processes
- any recalls that have occurred since the last BRCGS audit
- any recent quality issues, withdrawals or customer complaints, and other relevant performance data
- an outline of operational controls, such as internal audits, testing and traceability
- any significant changes since the last BRCGS audit
- inclusion of Part II, section 8 AOECs requirements.

Where the site is contracted with a new certification body, the site shall make the previous audit report and certificate available to the certification body, even if this was more than a year ago.

Submitting detailed information prior to the audit, and in the format requested by the certification body, may reduce the duration of the on-site audit and the time required to produce the final audit report; therefore sites are encouraged to fulfil such requests in a timely manner.

The time needed for the auditor and certification body to assess all the submitted documentation is additional to the duration of the audit.

3.1.3 Duration of the audit

Before the audit takes place, the certification body shall indicate the approximate duration of the audit. The typical duration of a standalone audit is 1.5–2 days (typically 8–9 hours/day, but never in excess of 10 hours/day) at the site.

Determination of the audit duration may be based on:

- the number of employees – as full-time equivalent employees per main shift, including seasonal workers
- the size of the manufacturing facility, including on-site storage facilities
- the number of HACCP plans (or food safety plans) included within the scope. For the purpose of the determination of the duration, a plan corresponds to a family of products with similar hazards and similar production technology.

It is recognised that other factors may also influence the determination but are considered less significant and therefore shall not influence the audit duration by more than 30% of the total calculated audit time. These factors include:

- whether it is an initial certification audit
- shortfalls in the information provided prior to the audit, as specified in section 3.1.2
- the complexity of the manufacturing process
- the number of product lines
- the age of the site and the impact on material flow
- the labour intensity of the processes
- communication difficulties (e.g. language)
- the number of non-conformities recorded in the previous audit (requiring additional time to review the relevant systems and confirm implementation of effective preventive action)
- difficulties experienced during the audit requiring further investigation
- the quality of site preparation (e.g. documentation, HACCP, management systems).

If additional storage facilities, locations or head office assessments are included within the audit process, additional time shall be allocated for this over and above that indicated above.

The audit duration is an indication of the amount of time the audit is expected to take at the site. Additional time may be required for the review of any documentary evidence provided and completion of the final audit report.

Where the audit is combined with a GFSI-benchmarked scheme, BRCGS Global Standard START! Intermediate level, or equivalent food safety audit offered by a GFSI-benchmarked certification programme owner, the gluten-free audit shall add 0.5 days to the overall audit duration.

Deviation from the audit timeframe shall be justified and specified on the audit report.

3.2 The on-site audit

The on-site audit consists of the following stages:

- **Opening meeting** To confirm the scope, category and process of the audit.
- **Production facility inspection (e.g. site, production and storage)** To review practical implementation of the systems, including, for example, auditing good manufacturing practices, accuracy of process flow diagrams, product changeover and line start-up procedures, and observing product changeover procedures.
- **Discussions with site staff and managers** To confirm on-site procedures and the implementation of gluten controls.
- **Document review** To review the documented gluten-free management system and other associated documentation demonstrating compliance with the Standard's requirements.
- **Vertical audit, traceability challenge and mass balance** Including a review of all relevant records of production (e.g. raw material intake, production records, finished product checks and specifications).
- **Label review** Including a review of a sample of gluten-free product labels to check against specifications, the site's label development processes, legislation and, if applicable, appropriate trademark use with the necessary documented approval from BRCGS and/or the relevant coeliac association.
- **Review of production facility inspection** To verify and conduct further documentation checks.
- **Final review of findings** Conducted by the auditor in preparation for the closing meeting.
- **Closing meeting** To review the audit findings with the site (note that non-conformities are subject to subsequent independent verification by the certification body management).

The site shall fully assist the auditor at all times. It is expected that at the opening and closing meetings those attending on behalf of the site will be senior managers who have the appropriate authority to ensure that corrective action can be progressed if non-conformities are found. The most senior operations manager on site at the time of the audit or their nominated deputy shall be available at the audit, attend the opening and closing meetings, and be available for a discussion on the gluten-free management system (see Part II, clause 1.2.1).

The audit process gives emphasis to the practical implementation of gluten controls and general good manufacturing practices. It is expected that approximately 50% of the audit will be spent auditing production and site facilities, interviewing staff, observing processes and reviewing documentation in production areas with the relevant staff.

During the audit, detailed notes shall be made regarding the site's conformities and non-conformities against the Standard and these will be used as the basis for the audit report. The auditor shall assess the nature and severity of any non-conformity and discuss this with the accompanying manager at the time.

At the closing meeting, the auditor shall present their findings and reconfirm all non-conformities that have been identified during the audit but shall not make comment on the likely outcome of the certification process. Information on the process and timescales for the site to provide evidence to the auditor of the corrective action

to close any non-conformities must be given. A written summary of the non-conformities discussed at the closing meeting will be documented by the auditor either at the closing meeting or within 1 working day of completion of the audit.

After completion of the certification process, BRCGS will provide the site contact with instructions on how to manage the site's entry in the BRCGS Directory and the BRCGS certification integrity programme. The BRCGS Directory allows both the client and its nominated customers secure access to audit data, and the BRCGS certification integrity programme provides feedback systems enabling sites to communicate with the certification body and the BRCGS team.

The decision to award certification and subsequent audit frequency will be determined independently by the certification body management, following a technical review of the audit report (including non-conformities) and confirmation of the site's post-audit actions, including:

- closing out of any non-conformities
- completion of root cause analysis
- development of a preventive action plan.

All site actions shall be completed within the appropriate timescale.

The company will be informed of the certification decision following this review.

3.3 Non-conformities and corrective action

The level of non-conformity assigned by an auditor against a requirement of the Standard is an objective judgement with respect to level and risk. It is based on evidence collected and observations made during the audit. This is verified by the certification body management.

3.3.1 Non-conformities

There are three levels of non-conformity:

- **Critical** Where there is a critical failure to comply with food safety (in relation to gluten), or legal issue.
- **Major** Where there is a substantial failure to meet the requirements of any clause of the Standard, or a situation is identified which would, on the basis of available objective evidence, raise significant doubt as to the conformity of the product being supplied.
- **Minor** Where a clause has not been fully met but, on the basis of objective evidence, the conformity of the product is not in doubt.

The objective of the audit is to provide a true reflection of the standard of the operation and level of conformity against the Standard. Consideration should therefore be given to awarding a single major non-conformity where minor non-conformities are repeatedly raised against a particular clause of the Standard. Clustering of a significant number of minor non-conformities against a clause and recording this as a single minor non-conformity is not permitted. The certification body shall justify a high number (more than 10) minor non-conformities where one or no major non-conformities are given. This shall be detailed on the audit report.

3.3.2 Procedures for handling non-conformities and corrective action

Following identification of any non-conformities during the audit, the site shall undertake corrective action to remedy the immediate issue, analyse the underlying root cause of the non-conformity, and develop a preventive action plan to address the root cause and prevent recurrence.

The process for 'closing out' non-conformities depends upon the level of non-conformity and the number of non-conformities identified.

Critical non-conformities or a combination of non-conformities resulting in non-certification

In some circumstances the number or severity of non-conformities raised at the audit prevents the site from being certificated following that audit. This will be the case where:

- a critical non-conformity is raised and/or
- the number or type of non-conformities exceeds the limits for certification, as shown in Table 1.

The grading of non-conformities will be reviewed by the independent certification process of the certification body as soon as possible after the audit. Where the review confirms that a certificate cannot be awarded, the site will be required to undertake another full audit before assessment for certification. The re-audit shall be conducted by the same certification body which conducted the original audit.

Due to the nature and number of non-conformities, it is unlikely that these non-conformities can be addressed, and fully effective improvements implemented and established, within a 28-calendar-day period, although there may be some exceptions. Therefore, the re-audit shall not take place any earlier than 28 calendar days from the audit date.

Where this occurs at a certificated site, certification must be immediately withdrawn.

It is a requirement of some customers that they shall be informed when their suppliers have a critical non-conformity identified or fail to gain certification. In such circumstances the company shall immediately inform its customers and make them fully aware of the circumstances. Information on the corrective actions to be taken in order to address the non-conformities will also be provided to customers where required.

Major and minor non-conformities

No certificate shall be issued until major and minor non-conformities have been demonstrated as having been corrected, either permanently or via a temporary solution that is acceptable to the certification body.

For each non-conformity raised, the site shall, in addition to undertaking the necessary immediate corrective action, undertake a review of the underlying cause (root cause) of the non-conformity. The root cause shall be identified and a preventive action plan to correct it, including timescale, shall be provided to the certification body. A summary of the root cause and proposed preventive action shall be included in the audit report.

Close-out of non-conformities can be achieved in any of the following ways:

- objective evidence being submitted to the certification body, such as updated procedures, records, photographs or invoices for work undertaken
- remote audit techniques being used to assess corrective actions
- the certification body undertaking a further on-site visit.

An example of evidence submitted for the correction of a non-conformity is given in Appendix 7.

If satisfactory evidence of corrective action, the root cause analysis and a preventive action plan are not provided within the 28-calendar-day period allowed for submission following the audit, certification will not be granted. The site will then require a further full audit in order to be considered for certification.

Non-conformities from the previous certification audit shall also be checked during the next site audit to verify effective close-out. For each non-conformity at the last audit, the auditor will therefore expect to see the following:

- **Corrective actions** The site is required to implement corrective actions and report them to the certification body within 28 calendar days of the audit. The auditor shall therefore expect to see the corrective actions from the previous audit in operation (e.g. that the updated procedure submitted to the certification body as evidence of corrective action following the last audit is in use).

- **Root cause analysis** After being completed by the site following the last audit, the root cause analysis will have been submitted to the certification body, and full details should be available if the auditor requires them.
- **Preventive action** At the time of the previous certification decision, the site will have submitted a preventive action plan to the certification body but might not have completed the actual preventive action. The auditor will therefore expect to see evidence that the site has been effective in preventing recurrence of the non-conformity.

The certification body shall review objective evidence of corrective action completed prior to awarding a certificate.

3.4 Determining the audit frequency

The audit frequency is dependent on the number and severity of the non-conformities identified at the time of the audit. Non-conformities are verified by a technical review process by the certification body management. If the review results in a change in the number and/or severity of non-conformities, the site shall be notified.

Table 1: Audit frequency based on number and severity of non-conformities

Critical	Major	Minor	Process for corrective action	Frequency
0	0	7 or fewer	Provide objective evidence within 28 calendar days	12 months
0	1	5 or fewer		
0	0	8-10	Revisit to review corrective action within 28 calendar days	12 months with revisit
0	1	6-8		
		>10	Certificate not granted. Full re-audit required	Re-audit required
	1	>8		
	2 or more			
1 or more				

3.4.1 Revisits

Where a revisit is required to review the action taken in response to the non-conformities identified at the audit (i.e. sites with no Major and 8-10 Minors, or 1 Major and 6 -8 Minors), this will be scheduled to be completed within 28 calendar days.

The certification body shall assess whether a physical revisit is required or whether a remote audit will provide an effective assessment of the actions taken to close out the non-conformities. Where a remote assessment is considered effective, the certification body can offer this option to the site.

The primary focus of the revisit (whether physical or remote) will be on reviewing the effectiveness of the corrective actions taken. However, if any new non-conformities are identified then these must also be satisfactorily resolved before a certificate can be issued, although they will not affect the revisit frequency. The action taken to correct the non-conformity shall be recorded in the final audit report.

Where certification is not granted, a full re-audit shall be required.

3.4.2 Documentary evidence and remote auditing

Where a revisit is not required, suitable evidence of corrective action shall be provided to the certification body within 28 calendar days. The evidence shall clearly demonstrate that adequate corrective actions have been taken and implemented. There are two options for submitting this evidence:

- **A remote audit of the corrective action** To confirm that effective corrective action has been implemented (e.g. a review of documents, discussions with site staff, using webcams).
- **Provision of suitable documentary evidence** For example, updated procedures, records, photographs, and invoices for work completed.

If satisfactory corrective action cannot be effectively demonstrated to the satisfaction of the certification body, a revisit may be required before a certificate can be issued.

3.5 Audit reporting

Following each audit, a full written report shall be prepared in the agreed format. The report shall be produced in English or in another language, dependent upon user needs. Where the report is produced in a language other than English, the audit summary sections shall always be reported in English in addition to the other language.

The audit report shall provide the company and customers or prospective customers with a profile of the company and an accurate summary of the performance of the site against the requirements of the Standard.

The audit report must assist the reader to be informed of:

- the gluten controls in place and improvements since the last audit
- best practice systems, procedures or equipment in place
- non-conformities, the corrective action taken and plans to correct the root cause (preventive actions).

The report shall accurately reflect the findings of the auditor during the audit. Reports shall be prepared and issued so that the certification decision is confirmed within 42 calendar days of the completion of the full audit. Subsequently, the audit report shall be uploaded to and available from the BRCGS Directory within 49 days of the final day of the audit.

The BRCGS Directory is the source of accurate, authenticated and up-to-date certification status information. It enables a one-click audit report sharing option. Audit reports shall remain the property of the company commissioning the audit and shall not be released, whole or in part, to a third party unless the company has given prior consent or the release is otherwise required by law.

The audit report shall be uploaded to the BRCGS Directory in a timely manner irrespective of whether a certificate is issued. The owner of the audit report may allocate access to the audit report to customers or other parties in the BRCGS Directory.

The audit report and associated documentation including auditor's notes shall be stored safely and securely for a period of 5 years by the certification body.

3.6 Certification

After a review of the audit report and documentary evidence provided in relation to the non-conformities identified, a certification decision shall be made by the designated independent certification manager. Where a certificate is granted, this shall be issued by the certification body within 42 calendar days of the audit. The certificate shall conform to the format shown in Appendix 6. Logos used on certificates (e.g. the BRCGS and certification body logos) shall comply with their respective usage rules.

While the certificate is issued to the site, it remains the property of the certification body, and that body controls its ownership, use and display.

3.6.1 Determining certificate expiry dates for initial audits

Where a Global Standard Gluten-Free audit is conducted standalone, the certificate expiry date shall be calculated from the first day of the audit plus 12 months, plus 42 days.

Where the audit is combined with any GFSI-benchmarked scheme, BRCGS Global Standard START! at Intermediate level, or equivalent (to START!) food safety audit, the certificate expiry date shall conform to the protocol of the relevant food safety scheme.

3.7 Ongoing audit frequency and recertification

3.7.1 Scheduling re-audit dates

Where a standalone audit is conducted, the re-audit due date shall be calculated from the date of the first day of the initial audit (irrespective of whether further site visits were made to verify corrective actions arising from the initial audit) and not from the certificate issue date. Subsequent audits of certificated sites shall be scheduled to occur within a 28-calendar-day time period up to the next audit due date. Refer to Table 1 for more information.

This allows sufficient time for corrective action to take place in the event of any non-conformities being raised, without jeopardising continued certification.

Where an audit is combined with a GFSI-benchmarked certification audit, BRCGS Global Standard START! Intermediate level audit, or equivalent food safety audit offered by a GFSI-benchmarked certification programme owner, please refer to the audit protocol of the relevant Standard for calculation of re-audit dates.

It is the responsibility of the site to maintain certification, and the BRCGS Directory sends automatic reminders. Where an audit is delayed beyond the due date, except in justifiable circumstances (see section 3.7.2), this shall result in a major non-conformity being awarded at the next audit. Justifiable circumstances shall be documented in the audit report.

While the site shall be responsible for maintaining valid certification, the certification body shall assume responsibility for maintaining the ongoing audit programme.

Where a site cannot be certificated because of the number or severity of non-conformities identified during the audit, the site will require a further full audit before certification can be considered. Once the site has addressed the non-conformities that were raised, the new audit can be arranged. The re-audit shall not take place any sooner than 28 calendar days from the audit date. If the audit was a mandatory unannounced audit in combination with a GFSI-benchmarked scheme audit, the re-audit may be announced. The re-audit shall be completed by the same certification body unless a concession is granted by BRCGS for a change of certification body during this period.

If the site chooses to change certification body, the site must ensure that the new certification body is aware that the site is already certificated and provide the date of its last audit.

Sharing the last audit report is a mandatory requirement of the BRCGS audit protocol (see section 3.1.2). Where a site fails to share its last report in a timely manner, the new certification body will have access to the last audit report through the BRCGS Directory.

3.7.2 Certificate expiry – justifiable circumstances

There will be some circumstances where the certificate cannot be renewed due to the inability of the certification body to conduct an audit. These justifiable circumstances, which would not result in the assigning of a major non-conformity (see section 3.7.1), are applicable when the site is:

- situated in a specific country or an area within a specific country where there is government advice not to visit and there is no suitable local auditor
- within a statutory exclusion zone that could compromise food safety or animal welfare
- in an area that has suffered a natural or unnatural disaster, rendering the site unable to produce or the auditor unable to visit
- affected by conditions that do not allow access to the site or restrict travel (e.g. heavy snow)

- producing seasonal products where production is delayed by a late start to the season (e.g. due to weather or product availability).

Moving the audit date to a more 'acceptable' later date for reasons of combining audits, lack of personnel or undertaking building work are not acceptable reasons for missing the due date.

It is not a justifiable reason to delay audits where sites are not in full production; however, audits must be undertaken while products in scope are being manufactured.

If the renewal of the certificate is prevented due to these exceptional circumstances, the customer may still decide to take products from that site for an agreed time, as customers may still demonstrate legal compliance by other means, such as risk assessment and complaints records, to show that the site is still competent to continue production until another audit can be arranged.

Any trademark use associated with certification to the Standard must cease until the certificate has been renewed. Any products manufactured prior to certificate expiry may continue to bear the trademarks associated with certification to the Standard.

3.7.3 Audits undertaken prior to due dates

The due date of an announced renewal audit occurs within a 28-calendar-day window prior to the anniversary of the initial audit.

In some circumstances it is possible to undertake the audit earlier than the due date; for example, to reset the audit dates to allow combined audits with another scheme, or to include a product that is produced during a different season. Where an audit date is brought forward, the following rules shall apply:

- The audit report will detail the reasons why an audit has been brought forward.
- The next audit due date will be 'reset' to the 12 months from this 'new' audit date.
- The certificate (should it be issued) shall either:
 - have an expiry date of 12 months plus 42 calendar days from the new audit date; or
 - have an expiry date which corresponds to the relevant GFSI-benchmarked scheme, BRCGS Global Standard START!, or equivalent food safety audit with which the Global Standard Gluten-Free audit is combined.

3.7.4 Refusal of a company to undertake an audit

Sites are obliged to accommodate the auditor and allow the audit to commence upon the auditor's arrival at the site.

Therefore, if the auditor arrives for the audit and is denied access, the site's certification will be suspended. The site shall remain suspended until a new audit can be completed. The new audit will occur within the 4 months following the refused audit. The audit shall be completed by the same certification body unless a concession is granted by BRCGS for a change of certification body during this period.

Liability for the auditor's time shall be covered by the certification body's contract with the site. Therefore, if access is denied, the site may also be liable for the auditor's costs.

3.7.5 Non-availability of key staff at the opening and closing meetings or during the audit

The gluten-free management system team leader, or a nominated deputy, shall be present at the opening and closing meetings. Relevant staff shall also be available during the audit.

The absence of the gluten-free management system team leader shall not be accepted as a reason to prevent an audit going ahead.

3.7.6 No production activity on the day of the unannounced audit

As part of the audit planning, the site must notify the certification body of any days or times when operations are not undertaken. If the unannounced audit takes place on a date when the site is supposed to be operational, but on arrival the auditor finds that there is either no production or the only products being handled are outside the scope of the audit, then the audit cannot go ahead. A further unannounced audit will need to be arranged.

Liability for the auditor's time shall be covered within the certification body's contract with the site (see section 3.7.4).

3.7.7 Changing the certification body for an early re-audit

In addition to the situations described in section 3.7.3, an early re-audit may occasionally be requested by a site. In this situation, the early re-audit must be completed by the certification body that issued the current certificate.

However, in exceptional circumstances and if agreed in advance by BRCGS, a site may be permitted to change the certification body for this early re-audit. Justification for changing the certification body in this situation shall be provided in writing to the certification body, who in turn shall submit it to BRCGS for consideration through the formal concession process. Where a change in certification body in this instance has not been agreed in advance, a re-audit by the new certification body will be null and void and will not be accepted in the BRCGS Directory.

This requirement applies only when an early re-audit has been requested; it does not change the process for re-audits completed to the normal schedule.

3.7.8 Seasonal production sites

The glossary defines a seasonal production site as 'a site that is opened for a short duration (typically 12 weeks or less) during a 12 month cycle. For example, to specifically harvest and process a product'.

For seasonal sites, the scheduling of audits needs to be carefully planned so that:

- certification does not lapse: where the product harvest is dictated by weather and this affects the actual audit date (e.g. the season is later than expected), there is no penalty for a delay to the audit, although justification for this delay must be included in the audit report
- the site is in production, so that all of the requirements of the Standard can be assessed
- there is a minimum of 1 week's production records for the auditor to review.

Corrective actions can be closed out within 28 calendar days and therefore within the current season. In the event that the harvest is unavoidably early (e.g. due to weather conditions) and, as a consequence, there are fewer than 28 calendar days before the end of the season, it may not be possible to close out identified non-conformities within the season. In this situation, the same rules apply as for sites with very short seasons.

For very short seasons (i.e. less than 4 weeks), it may not be possible to close out identified non-conformities within the season. However, where major non-conformities are identified, these must be resolved before the end of the season or within 28 calendar days of the audit if the site is to gain certification. Where minor non-conformities cannot be closed out within the season, they may be accepted by the certification body if a suitable action plan is provided. These actions will be assessed prior to the beginning of the next season and verified at the next audit. Any non-conformities that are not adequately closed out by the next audit will have the potential to be raised as non-conformities against management commitment (see section 3.3.2). This will apply whether the certificate has lapsed or not.

Where a site is awarded a combination of non-conformities which result in a re-visit or re-audit being required, it is likely that the site will not be in production when the next audit would normally fall. In such circumstances, the next audit shall take place as soon as production has started in the new season. In this situation, the site may be required

to agree a course of action with its customers, since it will not be certificated at the beginning of the season, until the scheduled re-audit has taken place. Under no circumstances will the validity of the certificate be extended to accommodate this situation.

For true seasonal production sites there may be circumstances where the frequency of audits is reduced, occurring at intervals of more than 12 months. The on-site audit date will be dictated by product harvest, which may be affected by the weather. The certificate expiry dates in these circumstances will be controlled by the actual audit date rather than the anniversary of the initial audit date. Justification needs to be included on the audit report.

It is particularly important that seasonal sites are well organised to ensure that systems are in place prior to start-up; for example, pest control must be effective from day 1 of operations. The systems shall include internal audits completed prior to start-up.

For seasonal sites it is assumed that the site is not operational 'out of season' and therefore the requirements of the Standard concerning specified meetings or audits which would normally occur at regular intervals throughout the year would not be appropriate during the out-of-season period. However, as a general principle, the site must be able to demonstrate that these activities have taken place in a timely manner (i.e. before the start of the season and at appropriate regular intervals during the season). Sites will need to consider the timing of these activities so that actions, targets or objectives can be completed within meaningful timescales. A schedule must be in place and records available to demonstrate the outcomes.

A site that is open for 12 months of the year may process different products or complete different processes in different seasons, but it would not be classed as a seasonal production site because it operates all the year round. Wherever possible the audit date shall be selected to include the higher-risk or more complex production processes. For example, in a brewery the audit date is organised so that the bottling or packing operations are running at the time of the audit. Where the processes are significantly different and there are different product risks, it may be necessary for both products or processes to be audited. However, where the product safety risks are low, the higher-risk process shall be audited as normal and the other processes or products shall be audited by using historical records, with the auditor seeing sufficient objective evidence to confirm compliance with requirements that occurred at other times of the year.

4 Protocol for audits to include the AOECs-specific requirements

Introduction

This protocol covers audits that include the AOECs-specific requirements for access to the European market and use of the Crossed Grain Trademark (hereafter referred to as AOECs-specific requirements). These requirements appear in Part II, section 8 and are mandatory for sites:

- producing gluten-free food products which use, or aim to obtain the licence to use, the AOECs Crossed Grain Trademark on their brands for pre-packaged foods, or
- producing for existing or potential AOECs Crossed Grain Trademark's licence holder(s). It applies to foods and drinks for general consumption, and to foods and drinks that have been formulated, processed or prepared to meet the special dietary needs of people with coeliac disease and other people intolerant to gluten.

BRCGS has developed this section in partnership with the AOECs to enable food manufacturers to demonstrate that all necessary steps have been taken to gain permission to use the Crossed Grain Trademark.

The Crossed Grain Trademark is protected and can only be used under certain criteria, including having signed a valid licence contract. Companies wishing to use the trademark must contact the relevant AOECs member society prior to scheduling an audit.

Where licensed, the Crossed Grain Trademark may be used on packaging, promotional materials, websites, signage and corporate literature directly related to the licensed products.

An audit against either the AOECs Standard for Gluten-free Foods, or BRCGS Global Standard Gluten Free including the AOECs-specific requirements, is one of the steps that must be completed by food business operators prior to becoming licence holders of the Crossed Grain Trademark.

The AOECs-specific requirements in Part II, section 8 may be used globally and are in addition to any legislation applicable in the country of manufacture and the country of sale. Sites are expected to meet all the relevant legislative requirements.

When the AOECs-specific requirements are part of the scope of the audit, all sections of Part III Audit Protocol shall be followed.

4.1 Audit preparation

4.1.1 Selection of an audit option

Sites that are to be audited against the entire Standard, including the AOECs-specific requirements, have the option to be audited against the standalone and combined audit options listed in sections 2.2 and 2.3. If the site informs the certification body of their intention to have a blended audit, the certification body shall inform the relevant AOECs member society of the site's intention. The AOECs member society may decide not to accept this audit option. In these cases, the site will reconsider their audit options.

4.2 Self-assessment of compliance with the Standard

It is the responsibility of the site wishing to be audited against the AOECs-specific requirements that they consider whether products being manufactured at that site are eligible to bear the Crossed Grain Trademark. A list of foods which are not permitted to use the Crossed Grain Trademark can be found in the **AOECs Standard for Gluten-free Foods**.

Where newly built or 'commissioned' manufacturing units have been operating for fewer than three months, they shall ensure that they follow AOECs-specific guidelines.

4.3 Food business operator and AOECs member society contractual arrangements

Where a site is to be audited against the AOECs-specific requirements:

- If the site wants to use the Crossed Grain Trademark with a consumer's brand it shall make audit reports and certificates available to AOECs or the AOECs member society. Sharing of audit reports and certificates via the BRCGS Directory can be removed by the site at any time.
- The auditor(s) may be accompanied by other personnel for training, assessment or calibration purposes. This activity may include:
 - where applicable, witness audits by the relevant AOECs member society.

4.4 Scope of audit

4.4.1 Defining the audit scope

Where a site elects to be audited against the AOECs-specific requirements, the certification body shall verify that:

- a Crossed Grain Trademark licence has been applied for or is in place between the AOECs member society and the licence holder
- where the site is a different legal entity than the Crossed Grain Trademark licence holder, there is an agreement in place between the licence holder and the site

- the site produces for one or more brands that are, or aim to be, Crossed Grain Trademark licence holders
- products which use, or intend to use, the AOECs Crossed Grain Trademark fall under the product categories permitted by the AOECs Standard for Gluten-free Foods.

Where possible products bearing, or intending to bear, the Crossed Grain Trademark shall be in production at the time of the audit.

4.5 Audit planning

4.5.1 Preparation by the company

The site shall notify the certification body in advance of the audit that they intend to include the AOECs-specific requirements in the scope of the audit. This ensures that, where necessary, sufficient additional time can be scheduled and that an auditor with the appropriate qualifications to audit the additional requirements is selected. The site shall either contact AOECs at helpdesk@aoecs.org or the **AOECs member society** in the country in which the audit takes place to learn about the process to become a Crossed Grain Trademark license holder.

The certification body shall also contact the relevant AOECs member society to inform them of the site's intention to be audited against the AOECs-specific requirements. Where there is no **AOECs member society** in the country in which the audit takes place, the certification body shall contact AOECs at helpdesk@aoecs.org.

At the time of an announced audit, the site shall ensure active production of products that are relevant for the implementation of the AOECs-specific requirements. Where the site has opted into the unannounced audit programme, detailed information shall be given to the certification body regarding production planning so that an appropriate audit date can be selected.

4.5.2 Information to be provided to the certification body for audit preparation

The food business operator shall supply the certification body with any additional background information requested prior to the audit day to ensure the auditor is fully prepared to audit the AOECs-specific requirements.

This is likely to include information on the:

- the audit option preferred by the site (see section 4.1.1)
- the list of Registered Products and/or groups of products within the requirements' scope
- typical production schedules for gluten-free products
- typical production schedules for AOECs member society products.

Prior to an audit which includes the AOECs-specific requirements, the relevant AOECs member society will provide the certification body with documented evidence that the site:

- has applied to become an AOECs Crossed Grain Trademark license holder; or
- intends to manufacture for an AOECs Crossed Grain Trademark license holder; or
- manufactures for a brand which intends to become an AOECs Crossed Grain Trademark license holder.

The AOECs member society shall provide the certification body with a list of Registered Products which the site intends to be included in the Crossed Grain Trademark license(s). Sites may produce for more than one Crossed Grain Trademark license holder. The certification body will confirm with the relevant AOECs member society that the list of Registered Products provided by the site is consistent with the products to which the trademark will be applied.

4.5.3 Audit duration

It is not anticipated that a significant amount of additional time will be required to assess the AOECs-specific requirements which would alter the overall audit duration. However, where necessary, a maximum of one hour shall be allowed in addition to the extra time permitted in section 3.1.3. The certification body shall indicate the expected additional time requirements at the time of planning the audit.

4.6 The on-site audit

Compliance with the AOECs-specific requirements can only be assessed as part of an audit against the other requirements of the Standard and are expected to be integrated into the audit programme as appropriate.

4.7 Non-conformities and corrective action

4.7.1 Non-conformities

Non-conformities against the AOECs-specific requirements shall be graded in the same way as non-conformities identified against requirements of the rest of the Standard. More details on how non-conformities are graded can be found in section 3.3.1.

If the site receives a critical non-conformity or fails to gain certification at an audit which includes the AOECs-specific requirements, the certification body shall immediately notify the relevant AOECs member society.

4.7.2 Procedures for handling non-conformities and corrective action

Following identification of any non-conformities against the AOECs-specific requirements during the audit, the company must undertake corrective action to remedy the immediate issue. The process for 'closing out' non-conformities shall be undertaken in the same way as those identified against requirements of Part II, sections 1-7. The site must close out all non-conformities identified at the audit to achieve certification.

4.8 Certification

Certification to the AOECs-specific requirements can only be achieved if the site achieves certification to the Global Standard Gluten-Free. Where certification to the Standard is not achieved, certification to the AOECs requirements cannot be awarded, irrespective of whether the requirements of Part II, section 8 have been met.

4.9 Ongoing audit frequency and recertification

Prior to a recertification audit which includes the AOECs-specific requirements, the relevant AOECs member society will provide the certification body with documented evidence that the site is an AOECs Crossed Grain Trademark license holder or is manufacturing for an AOECs Crossed Grain Trademark license holder.

The AOECs member society shall provide the certification body with a current list of products being manufactured at the production site to be included in the relevant Crossed Grain Trademark license(s). Sites may produce for more than one Crossed Grain Trademark license holder. The auditor will confirm with the relevant AOECs member society that the list of products is consistent with the actual products to which the trademark is applied.

4.10 Communication with the AOECs member society

The site shall maintain communication with the relevant AOECs member society after the audit. In the event that any circumstances change within the certificated site which may affect the validity of the Crossed Grain Trademark license, the certificated site shall immediately notify the brand owner and the AOECs member society.

Circumstances may include but are not limited to:

- legal proceedings with respect to product safety or legality, or that which significantly affects the operation of the site
- enforcement by authorities related to product safety or legality (e.g. an enforcement notice)

- product recalls, food safety-related product withdrawals
- significant public food safety incidents, or any significant regulatory food safety non-conformities
- significant damage to the site (e.g. natural disaster such as flood or damage by fire)
- change of ownership (see Appendix 8 - Glossary)
- significant staff changes or prolonged shutdowns (e.g. considerable staff losses or the loss of key product safety roles)
- site relocation, closure or change of address (see section 5.1.2).

The AO ECS member society and/or the brand owner shall take appropriate steps to assess the situation and any implications for the Crossed Grain Trademark license and shall take appropriate action.

4.11 AO ECS-specific requirements for use of the Crossed Grain Trademark

Each of the AO ECS-specific requirements shall be met if the certificated site is to qualify for a license to use the Crossed Grain Trademark or sells to a brand owner which, either intends to become or, is already a Crossed Grain Trademark license holder.

Products covered by these requirements shall comply with the AO ECS Standard for Gluten-free Foods.

5 General protocol – post audit

5.1 Communication with certification bodies

5.1.1 Change of circumstances

In the event that any circumstances change within the site that may affect the validity of continuing certification, the site shall immediately notify the certification body. Circumstances may include:

- legal proceedings with respect to product safety or legality, or that which significantly affects the operation of the site
- enforcement by authorities related to product safety or legality (e.g. an enforcement notice)
- product recalls, food safety-related product withdrawals (BRCGS must also be notified - see Part II, clause 3.8.1, and where applicable, AO ECS and their member societies – See Part II, clause 8.1.2)
- significant public food safety incidents, or any significant regulatory food safety non-conformities
- significant damage to the site (e.g. natural disaster such as flood or damage by fire)
- change of ownership (see Appendix 9 – Glossary)
- any significant change to the operation or scope
- significant staff changes or prolonged shutdowns (e.g. considerable staff losses or the loss of key product safety roles)
- site relocation, closure or change of address (see section 5.1.2).

The certification body in turn shall take appropriate steps to assess the situation and any implications for the certification and shall take appropriate action.

Information shall be provided to the certification body by the site on request so that an assessment can be made as to the effect on the validity of the current certificate.

The certification body may, as appropriate:

- confirm the validity of the certificate is not affected
- suspend certification pending further investigation

- require further details of the corrective action, root cause analysis and preventive action plan implemented by the site
- undertake a site visit to verify the control of processes and confirm continued certification
- withdraw certification
- issue a new certificate with the new owner's details.

Changes to the certification status of a site shall be recorded in the BRCGS Directory.

In the event of an incident, the effectiveness of corrective and preventive actions taken by the site will also be reviewed at the next scheduled BRCGS audit to confirm their implementation and continued effectiveness.

5.1.2 Changes in site address

As certification is site specific, if a site moves to new premises, the current certificate is no longer valid and shall be withdrawn. The site will require a full reaudit at their new premises against the Standard's requirements, plus the requirements of a GFSI-benchmarked scheme, BRCGS Global Standard START! Intermediate level, or equivalent food safety programme offered by a GFSI-benchmarked certification programme owner.

The company, can however, keep the BRCGS site code for purposes of the BRCGS Directory as this will keep the audit history of the company and the sharing settings with customers. In this case the address details can be updated on the BRCGS Directory.

Any use of BRCGS-managed trademarks at the new premises shall not commence until certification has been granted.

5.2 Position statements

During the lifetime of the Standard, the BRCGS technical advisory committee (TAC) (see Part IV, section 2.2) may be asked to:

- review the wording of a requirement in the Standard or protocol
- provide an interpretation for a requirement
- rule on the grading of a non-conformity against a clause.

The outcome will be published on the BRCGS website as a 'position statement'. Position statements are binding on how the audit and certification processes are carried out. They are considered to be an extension of the Standard.

Sites shall be aware of any published position statements relating to the Standard and, where necessary, ensure that the information is transferred into action. Non-compliance with a relevant position statement may result in a non-conformity against clause 1.1.3 or a specific clause of the Standard.

Position statements are published on the BRCGS website and on Participate. They are also communicated electronically to companies and certification bodies (e.g. in bulletins and newsletters).

More information on the development and publication of position statements can be found in Appendix 9.

5.3 Extension to scope

Requests for extensions to scope must follow the protocol of the GFSI-benchmarked scheme, BRCGS Global Standard START! or equivalent food safety scheme offered by a GFSI-benchmarked certification programme owner to which the site is certificated.

5.4 Certification withdrawal

The certificate may be withdrawn by the certification body in a number of circumstances where the site may no longer comply with the requirements of the BRCGS certification integrity programme. Examples of these instances are:

- evidence that the site no longer complies with the requirements and protocol of the Standard, raising significant doubt of the conformity of the products produced
- failure to implement adequate corrective action plans within appropriate timescales
- evidence of falsification of records
- failure to fulfil contractual obligations (e.g. payment failure).

Where certification is withdrawn, the site shall notify BRCGS and any brand owners which use a BRCGS-managed trademark. BRCGS can be notified via brcgs.enquiries@lgcgroup.com.

Use of BRCGS-managed trademarks shall cease until certification has been reinstated.

5.5 Appeals

The company has the right to appeal the certification decision made by the certification body and any appeal should be made in writing to the certification body within 7 calendar days of receipt of the certification decision.

The certification body shall have a documented procedure for the consideration and resolution of appeals against the certification decision. These investigative procedures shall be independent of the individual auditor and certification manager. The documented appeals procedure of the relevant certification body will be made available to the site on request. Appeals will be finalised within 30 calendar days of receipt. A full written response will be given after the completion of a full and thorough investigation into the appeal.

It should be noted that where an appeal is made against a non-conformity, this does not delay or postpone the corrective action, root cause analysis or development of a preventive action plan (see section 3.3.2). The relevant information is still expected within 28 calendar days of the completion of the audit. In the event of an unsuccessful appeal, the certification body has the right to charge costs for conducting the appeal.

5.6 Surveillance of certificated companies

For certificated companies, the certification body or BRCGS may carry out further audits or question activities to validate continued certification at any time. These visits may take the form of announced or unannounced visits to undertake either a full or part audit. These audits form part of the BRCGS certification integrity programme with random visits to certificated sites. Refusal of access to the site or unwillingness to cooperate with the auditor may affect certification status.

Any non-conformities identified at a visit must be corrected and closed out within the normal protocol (i.e., within 28 calendar days of the visit) and reviewed and accepted by the certification body. If there is no intention on behalf of the site to take appropriate corrective actions or the corrective actions are deemed inappropriate, certification shall be withdrawn. The ultimate decision to suspend or withdraw certification remains with the certification body. Any change in certification status shall be notified to BRCGS by the certification body and the status in the BRCGS Directory shall be amended accordingly.

In the event that certification is withdrawn or suspended by the certification body, the company shall immediately inform its customers and make them fully aware of the circumstances relating to the withdrawal or suspension. Information on the corrective actions to be taken in order to reinstate certification status should also be provided to customers.

5.7 BRCGS logos

Achieving BRCGS certification is something of which to be proud. Companies that achieve certification are qualified to use the BRCGS Gluten-Free logo on site stationery and other marketing materials. Use of the BRCGS Gluten-Free logo is not affected by any exclusions from scope listed in section 2.8.2. Information and conditions relating to the use of the BRCGS logos is available from brcgs.com/resources/brcgs-brand-guidelines. If a site is no longer certificated because of certificate expiry, withdrawal or suspension, it shall no longer use the logo or certificate claiming certification.

The BRCGS logo is not a product certification mark and neither it nor any reference to certification may be used on products or product packaging. Any certificated site found to be misusing the logo will be subject to the BRCGS complaints and referral process (see Part IV, section 3.3) and may risk suspension or removal of its certification.

5.8 Global Standard Gluten-Free Trademark Use

The Global Standard Gluten-Free is endorsed by both Beyond Celiac and Celiac Canada. BRCGS also has agreements in place with ACELMEX in Mexico/Latin America and the Association of European Coeliac Societies (AOECS). All of these celiac/coeliac associations allow certificated sites to place their trademarks on consumer-facing packaging, provided they comply with the appropriate terms and conditions for trademark use.

In addition, BRCGS allows use of the Informed Gluten-Free trademark in regions of the world not already covered by the associations mentioned above such as the Middle East, Asia, Africa and Australasia.

After certification has been granted, permission to use any of the trademarks must be sought from either BRCGS (for Beyond Celiac, Celiac Canada and Informed Gluten-Free trademark use), or from the relevant AOECS member society or ACELMEX (for the use of any of the other trademarks permitted via certification to the Standard). More information can be found on the trademarks section of the Gluten-Free pages of the BRCGS website.

The company may display the trademark(s) permitted via certification to the Standard on its web site(s), electronic or 'hard copy' promotional, marketing and communication collaterals. Trademark use shall only be in direct association with products, permitted to display the trademark(s). Where BRCGS-managed trademarks are used, there shall be no reference to "product certification" on product labels, collaterals, or on printed or electronic information such as advertising and promotional information.

Further information and conditions relating to the use of the Beyond Celiac, Celiac Canada and Informed Gluten-Free trademarks is available in the BRCGS Free-From Trademark Guideline.

If a site is no longer certificated because of certificate expiry, withdrawal or suspension, it shall no longer use the trademarks until certification has been reinstated or renewed. Any certificated site found to be misusing the trademarks will be subject to the BRCGS complaints and referral process (see Part IV, section 3.3) and may risk suspension or removal of its certification.

5.9 BRCGS Directory

The BRCGS Directory is the database of all audits conducted against a BRCGS Standard and all BRCGS-approved certification bodies and their auditors. The Directory hosts all audit reports and certificates in PDF format, including archived audit documents from 2008 onwards.

Audit data can be added to or edited on the Directory by BRCGS-approved certification bodies only. Audit reports and associated confidential content can only be accessed following secure sign-in.

Certification bodies are also responsible for maintaining all details about a site, including the site's name, address and contact details. All certification bodies are assessed and graded by BRCGS according to how quickly and accurately they update audit data.

The Directory also features a publicly accessible search function displaying certification data for currently certificated sites. Sites wishing to be excluded from public listing should contact their certification body.

5.9.1 Site code

All audited sites are allocated a unique 6-, 7- or 8-digit reference number known as a site code. Site codes are generated when a site record is initially created and added to the Directory by a certification body. The site code remains unchanged, regardless of subsequent auditing certification bodies, Standard status or audit status.

Site codes can be located on the top right-hand corner of the first page of all audit reports and on corresponding certificates.

The listing for any certificated site can be located in the public area of the Directory by adding the site code to the 'site code' search field. If no results are returned for a search, contact BRCGS to confirm certification authenticity.

5.9.2 Audit-sharing

The Directory allows audit owners to share their audit reports with customers, including retailers, manufacturers, suppliers and other Directory-registered specifiers.

Once audit-sharing has been configured, customers can access the full current, archived and future audit documents (as they become available) without any further administration. An audit owner can cancel sharing at any time. Audit documents shared in the Directory cannot be edited or otherwise changed by the audit owner; therefore, audits obtained from the Directory can be considered as complete and authenticated.

5.9.3 Site-sharing

Only certification bodies authorised by the site owner can edit a site record. In the event of a transfer from one certification body to another, the new certification body must be given access to the site's records before a new audit can be added for that site or any edits to the site details can be made. Site-sharing can be arranged by the site owner on the Directory or by BRCGS upon request.

5.9.4 Notification emails

The Directory notifies audit owners, and anybody who has shared access to the audit, if a site's certification is suspended, withdrawn or expires without replacement. Notifications are via automated email and can be turned off if not required.

5.9.5 Directory assistance and contacting BRCGS

For further information regarding the BRCGS Directory, including how to configure audit-sharing with a customer or site-sharing with a certification body, visit the BRCGS Directory and click on the 'Audit & Site Sharing' and 'Contact' tabs.

Part IV

Management and governance

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Part IV

Management and governance

1 Requirements for certification bodies

The Global Standard Gluten-Free is a third-party certification scheme. In this scheme, businesses are certificated upon completion of a satisfactory audit by an auditor employed by an independent third party – the certification body.

The site shall select a BRCGS-approved certification body to undertake the audit. BRCGS lays down detailed requirements that a certification body shall satisfy in order to gain approval and operates a comprehensive compliance programme to ensure high standards are maintained.

Further details are available in the document 'Requirements for certification bodies offering certification against the criteria of BRCGS' (BRCGS004), which is available on request.

Sites seeking to be audited against the Standard should assure themselves that they are using an approved BRCGS certification body. A list of all certification bodies approved by BRCGS is available in the BRCGS Directory.

All approved certification bodies shall have a contract in place with BRCGS.

2 Technical governance of the Standard

The Standard and associated scheme is managed by BRCGS with governance and technical advice provided through a number of committees (see Figure 2), each of which works to a set of defined terms of reference.

2.1 International advisory boards

The BRCGS International Advisory Boards (IABs) consist of industry executives from international retail, service and manufacturing businesses.

The IABs are responsible for providing insight and advice on BRCGS strategy and development in areas of assurance and in overseeing the delivery of governance of BRCGS Standards and services.

2.2 Technical advisory committees

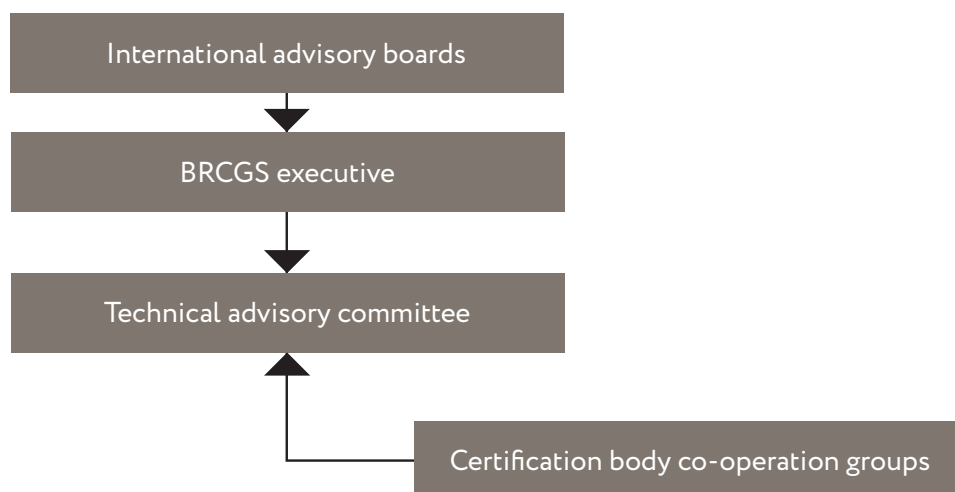
Each Global Standard is supported by at least one technical advisory committee (TAC), which meets regularly to discuss technical, operational and interpretational issues related to the Standard. BRCGS provides the technical secretariat for these groups.

The TAC for the Global Standard Gluten-Free is made up of senior technical managers representing the users of the Standard and includes representatives of retailers, food manufacturers, coeliac/ceeliac associations, certification bodies and independent technical experts.

The Standard is reviewed at regular intervals, usually around every 3 years, to assess the need for updating a new issue. This work is undertaken by the TAC, which is expanded for the purpose to include other available expertise.

The TAC also reviews auditor competence requirements, proposed training materials and supplementary technical documents supporting the Standards.

Figure 2: Technical governance structure for management of the Standard



2.3 The certification body co-operation groups

BRCGS encourages and facilitates meetings of the certification bodies participating in the scheme (co-operation groups) to discuss matters arising from the implementation of the Standard and issues of interpretation. These groups report regularly to BRCGS on operational issues, implementation and suggested improvements. Representatives from the co-operation groups attend the TAC meetings.

3 Achieving consistency – certification integrity

The maintenance of a high and consistent standard of audit and certification, and the ability of the certificated sites to maintain the standards achieved at the audit, are essential to provide confidence in the scheme and the value of certification. BRCGS therefore has an active compliance programme to ensure high standards are maintained.

The Global Standards may only be certificated by certification bodies registered and approved by BRCGS. All auditors undertaking audits against the Standard shall meet the BRCGS auditor competency requirements and shall be registered with BRCGS. All audits undertaken against the Standard shall be uploaded to the BRCGS Directory, which provides BRCGS with an oversight of the activity of the certification bodies and the opportunity to review the quality of the reports produced.

To support the Standard, BRCGS operates a certification integrity programme which reviews the performance of the certification bodies, samples the quality of audit reports, assesses the levels of understanding of the scheme requirements and investigates any issues or complaints. As part of this programme, BRCGS provides feedback on the performance of each certification body through a key performance indicator (KPI) programme. The results are publicly available as a 1–5-star rating of each certification body that is listed in the BRCGS Directory.

BRCGS audits the offices of certification bodies and accompanies auditors at site audits to observe their performance. BRCGS also undertakes independent visits to certificated sites to ensure that standards of food safety and quality are being maintained in line with their certification status and that the audit and reporting process are to the expected standard.

3.1 Calibrating auditors

A key component of the scheme is the calibration of auditors to ensure a consistent understanding and application of the requirements. All certification bodies are required to have processes to calibrate their own auditors. An essential element of the training and calibration of auditors is the witnessed audit programme. Auditors are observed during an audit and provided with feedback on the performance of the audit. In order to ensure consistency between certification bodies, an audit may be witnessed by a BRCGS representative. Guidelines apply to these activities to ensure that sites are not disadvantaged by the presence of two auditors. This process forms an essential part of the scheme and sites are obliged to permit witnessed audits as part of the conditions for certification.

3.2 Feedback

Companies audited against the Standard may wish to provide feedback to the certification body or BRCGS on the performance of the auditor. Such feedback sent to BRCGS will be considered in confidence. Feedback provides a valuable input to the monitoring programme for certification body performance.

Sites can use BRCGS' confidential reporting system, **TellBRCGS**, to report any wrongdoing related to BRCGS certificated sites, certification bodies or auditors.

If you have concerns regarding the non-conformities raised at your audit, you should first make a formal appeal to your certification body. If you subsequently have concerns about the way the appeal has been handled by your certification body, you may raise it through TellBRCGS.

All audited sites are also invited to complete a feedback survey which is treated confidentially.

3.3 Complaints

BRCGS has implemented a formal complaints process, which is available to organisations involved with BRCGS Global Standards. Details of the BRCGS complaints process can be found on the BRCGS website. Complaints can be reported confidentially on the Tell BRCGS reporting system.

From time to time, failure to apply the principles and criteria of the Standard at certificated sites may be reported to BRCGS by, for example, retailers and companies conducting their own audits. In this event, BRCGS will conduct an investigation which may include, as appropriate, a visit to the site by BRCGS, either announced or unannounced, or a request to the certification body to investigate; this may also include a visit to the site. BRCGS will require a full investigation of the issues raised, and a report from the certification body will be submitted to BRCGS within 28 calendar days (or a shorter time in urgent cases).

3.4 AOECs-specific requirements

During the term of the collaboration between AOECs and BRCGS, AOECs gives permission for BRCGS to include Part II, section 8 of the Standard under the management and governance described above, notwithstanding additional specific management and governance requirements that may be included in the Agreement between the two organisations.

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Appendix 1

Other BRCGS standards

BRCGS has developed a range of Global Standards which set out the requirements for the manufacture of food and consumer products; the packaging used; the storage, distribution and procurement of these products; and the retail environment in which they are sold. These Standards provide precedents, frameworks and resources for the auditing and certification of suppliers.

The **Global Standard Agents and Brokers** is a certification standard applicable to companies that buy and sell products or facilitate the trade of products but do not manufacture, process, pack or store the traded products in their own facilities or on their own sites (although such activities may be offered to their customers via subcontracted service providers). The standard is GFSI-benchmarked.

The **Global Standard Consumer Products** is a certification standard applicable to the manufacture and assembly of consumer products. To reflect the needs of the market, it is composed of two separate standards: personal care and household, and general merchandise. Each standard sets out the requirements for the manufacture of relevant non-food consumer products, including the manufacture of raw materials and components, as well as finished products. There are two levels of certification to this standard: foundation and higher.

Ethical Trade and Responsible Sourcing (ETRS) is a certification standard that is applicable to manufacturers and processors of food and non-food products; it also covers the facilities provided by agents and brokers, storage and distribution, and the provision of services to these companies. It sets out the requirements for the sites to manage ethical trade and responsible sourcing issues. In addition, there is a separate risk assessment module that provides a 'health check' on the way sites manage ethical trade issues. This module can be bolted onto a product safety audit or conducted separately.

The **Global Standard Food Safety** is a certification standard that sets out the requirements for the manufacture of processed foods and the preparation of primary products supplied as retailer-branded products, branded food products and food or ingredients for use by food service companies, catering companies and food manufacturers. The standard is GFSI-benchmarked.

The **Global Standard Packaging Materials** is a GFSI-benchmarked certification standard that lays down the requirements for the manufacture of packaging materials used for food and consumer products. Food and consumer product businesses may request their packaging suppliers to be certificated against this standard.

The **Plant-Based Global Standard** is a certification standard concerned with the control of materials of animal origin in the manufacture, processing and packing of plant-based processed foods and ingredients, pet foods, and natural health products. It is based on a comprehensive management system approach to ensure the integrity of plant-based products.

The **Global Standard Retail** is a certification standard that sets out the requirements to manage product safety, quality and legality for businesses in the food retail industry. The scope of certification covers applicable operations both at the retailer's head office and at its respective retail stores.

The **Global Standard START!** was developed to complement the BRCGS Global Standard Food Safety. It recognises and encourages the development of food safety systems in small sites where the full requirements of the Global Standard Food Safety may not always be practical or add value.

The **Global Standard Storage and Distribution** is a certification standard that sets out the requirements for the storage, distribution, wholesaling and contracted services of packaged food products, packaging materials and consumer goods. The standard is not applicable to storage facilities under the direct control of the production facility management, which are covered by the relevant manufacturing standard (e.g. the Global Standard Food Safety). The standard is GFSI-benchmarked.

Appendix 2

Introduction to coeliac disease

Coeliac disease is a multi-system autoimmune disorder that is triggered by ingestion of gluten, a protein found in wheat, rye, and barley. Coeliac disease prevents the body's small intestine from absorbing nutrients and there is currently no cure. The only mitigation or treatment is a strict gluten-free diet. Foods manufactured at sites certificated to the Global Standard Gluten-Free will satisfy that need.

The global prevalence of coeliac disease in the general population is approximately 1.4%, with some regional differences. A similar disease prevalence has been found in other countries mostly populated by individuals of European origin, for example Australia and Argentina. Coeliac disease is a common disorder in North Africa, the Middle East, and India. At 5.6%, the highest coeliac disease prevalence in the world has been described in the Saharawi from the area known as Western Sahara.

In the last few years, non-coeliac gluten sensitivity has been recognised by the scientific community as a gluten-related disorder. The term non-coeliac gluten sensitivity is used to describe the clinical state of individuals who develop symptoms when they consume gluten-containing foods and feel better on a gluten-free diet but do not have coeliac disease. The global prevalence is estimated to be 6% of the population, and has shown to be potentially as high as 13% in the UK. Currently, there is no clear pathology or diagnostic criteria, and the diagnosis of non-coeliac gluten sensitivity is established by excluding coeliac disease. However, a gluten-free diet normally reduces the effects.

As coeliac disease exists in the population with a 1.4% prevalence, this is similar to, or exceeds the relative levels of reaction to other common allergens such as shellfish (1.4%), tree nuts (1.2%), peanut (1.8%), and egg (0.8%). The estimated prevalence of coeliac disease plus non-coeliac gluten sensitivity at approximately 6% is comparable to that of all priority allergens combined, which is 7.5%. This is in the order of more than 60 million consumers requiring a gluten-free diet in Canada, USA, and Europe combined.

Coeliac disease has many signs and symptoms, and these vary widely from person to person. Symptoms can range from very severe neurological difficulty all the way down to the complete absence of symptoms. However, classical symptoms include abdominal pain, bloating, chronic diarrhea, and weight loss. Less common symptoms include anaemia, joint and bone pain, elevated liver enzymes, migraines, and infertility. There is no cure for coeliac disease. The only mitigation option for those who are afflicted is to dedicate themselves to a 100% gluten-free diet (i.e., all foods must contain less than 20ppm gluten, with the optimal goal that none is detected), which is very difficult. Without a strict gluten-free diet, those with coeliac disease can develop further symptoms and complications such as osteoporosis, infertility and miscarriage, type 1 diabetes, cancers, other autoimmune conditions such as multiple sclerosis and neurological conditions such as epilepsy.

For those pursuing a gluten-free diet, seeking out inherently gluten-free products or simply avoiding products listing gluten-containing ingredients has proven not to be effective in avoiding short-term and long-term debilitating effects.

Another significant contributing factor is that consumers fail to correctly distinguish gluten-containing ingredients. A Canadian study has found that adults with coeliac disease who are trying to follow a gluten-free diet have difficulty choosing appropriate gluten-free foods based on product labeling information alone. This leads to suggestions that explicit labeling that identifies gluten-free products is helpful.

Appendix 3

Auditing of activities managed by a head office or central function

A food manufacturer may have multiple locations, with a head office or central function managing some of the requirements within the scope of the Standard. Typically, this may apply to activities such as purchasing, supplier approval, product development, product recall and, occasionally, document control and procedures (where there is a group-shared quality management system).

In order to complete the audit process and make a certification decision, all the requirements within the scope of the Standard must be assessed. This means that any centrally managed systems shall be included within the audit process; however, there are two alternative processes for achieving this:

- Request and review information while at each manufacturing site as part of the site audit (one-stage audit).
- Undertake a separate audit of the centrally managed processes at the group/head office location (two-stage audit).

Approach 1 – Requesting and reviewing information at the manufacturing site (one-stage audit)

This is recommended only where:

- satisfactory links can be established with the central office (e.g. ICT or video-conferencing links to allow interview of relevant personnel; email or online systems to allow documents to be requested and viewed) and arrangements can be put in place to ensure availability of the relevant personnel
- head office involvement in site operations is limited, or the amount and type of information can be effectively reviewed and challenged remotely.

Note: where a site elects for the information to be assessed during the manufacturing site audit and satisfactory information cannot be provided during the audit, unsubstantiated requirements shall be recorded as non-conformities on the site audit report.

Reporting

The audit report shall make it clear where a requirement is managed by a central office, together with a comment on how the company complies with the requirement.

Non-conformities

Non-conformities raised against a centrally operated requirement shall be recorded on the audit report and included within the count of non-conformities.

Corrective action, root cause and preventive action plans shall be assessed in the same way as non-conformities raised at the manufacturing site. Non-conformities shall be satisfactorily corrected before a certificate can be issued to the site.

Subsequent manufacturing site audits

The central system requirements shall be challenged and evidence of compliance shall be provided at each manufacturing site audit.

Approach 2 – Separate central system and manufacturing site audits (two-stage audit)

This approach is recommended where it is not practical to effectively assess requirements from the manufacturing site. For example, where:

- practical arrangements to allow assessment cannot be provided
- there are too many centrally managed requirements to effectively review them remotely.

This approach shall be offered to the site being audited and undertaken when requested.

Stage 1 – Central system audit

The audit of the central system shall be completed before undertaking the manufacturing site audit.

Where the audit of the Standard is combined with an unannounced food safety audit, the central system audit may be completed as an announced audit, while the production site audits shall be completed as unannounced audits. The date of the central system audit shall ensure that there is sufficient time for the unannounced audits of the participating manufacturing sites to occur before each site's audit due date.

The company can select the blended audit option for its central system and site audits. This will operate in accordance with the blended audit protocol of the relevant food safety standard. The clauses that can be audited remotely are in accordance with the normal audit protocol (i.e. based on the certification body risk assessment and the colour-coding of the clauses in Part II). In some situations, this may mean that the auditor does not need to visit the head office as all the clauses are appropriate for remote assessment. If the head office audit contains a mixture of clauses (i.e. some that require on-site assessment and others that may be audited remotely), the company may elect to have:

- a blended audit of the central system (i.e. a two-part audit, partially remote and partially on site at the head office)
- a full on-site head office audit
- a remote head office audit with the remaining on-site elements being assessed at each of the site audits.

The audit shall assess both how the central system complies with the relevant requirements of the Standard and how well the central system interacts with the manufacturing site operation.

Reports for the central system audit

The certification body may produce a report of the central system audit for the benefit of the company. However, as this audit will include only some of the requirements of the Standard:

- the audit frequency of the site shall not be affected
- no certificate may be issued
- the report must be in a format which is clearly different from the full audit report.

The central system report shall not be uploaded to the BRCGS Directory, but the findings of the central system audit shall be incorporated into the final audit report of each of the associated manufacturing sites.

Recording non-conformities identified at the central system audit

All non-conformities identified at the central system audit shall be recorded on the audit report of the first manufacturing site audited after that audit, irrespective of whether they have been closed out before the manufacturing site audit. However, only those non-conformities raised at the central system audit that have not been closed out to the satisfaction of the certification body at the time of the first manufacturing site audit shall be counted when calculating the audit frequency for that manufacturing site.

Any non-conformities identified at the central system audit which are still outstanding at the time of further manufacturing site audits (second, third, etc.) shall be included on those manufacturing site reports and be included when calculating the audit frequency for those sites.

Closure of corrective actions, root cause analysis and preventive action plans

Corrective actions, root cause analysis and preventive action plans that are required following the central system audit shall be assessed in the same way as actions raised at the manufacturing site audit, and must be satisfactorily completed before a certificate can be issued to the manufacturing site. This may be documentary evidence, remote assessment or a revisit, as appropriate.

Stage 2 – Manufacturing site audits

Information from the central system audit (including any evidence of corrective action taken) shall be made available to the auditors of the associated manufacturing sites by the certification body.

The auditor shall establish that the central system components assessed are the same as those operating at the manufacturing site. The auditor shall verify any corrective or preventive actions already taken following the central system audit.

Audit duration

It may be possible to reduce the duration of the manufacturing site audit to take account of systems already audited at a central office.

Audit report

The final report shall be applicable to the manufacturing site.

The central system audit shall be commented upon in the company profile; for example: 'An audit was carried out at the central office at on the to assess requirements as indicated in the report.'

The key personnel may include the names of key staff present at the central system audit.

The manufacturing site audit report shall include information about how both the site and the central system comply with the requirements of the Standard. The report shall indicate where a requirement is managed by a central office and provide an explanation of how that requirement is satisfied.

Corrective action, root cause analysis and preventive action

The 28 calendar days allowed for evidence of corrective action, root cause analysis and the development of preventive action plans start from the date of the manufacturing site audit.

It is the responsibility of the site to ensure that evidence of the central system's actions have been provided to the certification body in order to allow the site to become certificated. This will require effective communication with the central system's office.

Where the central system's corrective actions have been accepted prior to the first manufacturing site audit, this shall be indicated on the first manufacturing site audit report and the date of acceptance of the action indicated in the 'action taken' section of the non-conformity report.

Certificate

The certificate, where awarded, is issued to the manufacturing site. The re-audit date for the manufacturing site shall be 12 months from the initial audit date.

The central system audit shall be carried out every 12 months and shall occur before the anniversary of the audit of the first manufacturing site.

Audits of other manufacturing sites associated with the central system

Usually there will be several manufacturing sites associated with a central system. The information from the annual central system audit shall be used for each subsequent manufacturing site audit.

Non-conformities originally raised at the central system audit and effectively corrected before the audit of a manufacturing site shall not be recorded as non-conformities on the site audit report. Any outstanding non-conformities at the time of the manufacturing site audit shall, however, be included within that site's report and calculation for audit frequency purposes.

BRCGS shall be contacted for advice before carrying out audit programmes for more complex arrangements of sites and centralised systems.

Scheduling re-audit dates

The head office of the company shall be visited annually.

Re-audits of individual sites under the head office's control are performed at a frequency dependent on the previous audit performance of that particular site.

Appendix 4

Qualifications, training and experience requirements for auditors

Full details of the BRCGS requirements for certification bodies and auditors are published separately from this document. Copies are available on request.

The following summarises the minimum requirements for auditors to conduct audits against the Standard.

Education and work experience

The auditor shall have a degree in a food-related, bioscience or science and engineering discipline.

The auditor shall have a minimum of five years' post-qualification experience related to the food industry. This shall involve work in quality assurance or food safety, technical management or risk management functions within manufacturing, retailing, inspection or enforcement at a managerial, decision-making level.

The auditor shall be able to demonstrate an understanding and knowledge of specific product categories for which they are approved. The verification of the auditor's ability to carry out work within specific product categories is the responsibility of the certification body.

Qualifications

Lead auditor qualification

The auditor shall have a recognised auditor qualification, including training on quality management systems of 40 hours' duration with an examination. Examples of recognised courses are:

- Management System Lead Assessor course (e.g. IRCA registered course)
- ASQ Certified Quality Auditor or Exemplar Global qualification
- BRCGS Lead Auditor course delivered by a BRCGS-approved trainer.

Other GFSI-benchmarked certification programmes, such as the Safe Quality Food (SQF), Food Safety System Certification (FSSC) 22000 and International Featured Standards (IFS) lead auditor training, are also accepted.

HACCP qualification

The auditor shall have completed a training course in HACCP, based on the principles of Codex Alimentarius, of at least two days' duration, and be able to demonstrate competence in the understanding and application of HACCP principles. It is essential that the course is recognised by the industry as being appropriate and relevant.

In exceptional cases, where the auditor can demonstrate practical use and application within the previous 5 years to a high level (e.g. being a recognised trainer of HACCP), a formal training course may not be required.

Global Standard Gluten-Free (Issue 4) qualification

Auditors shall have successfully completed the Global Standard Gluten-Free (Issue 4) Auditor training course (and the corresponding examination). This training course may also be delivered by a trainer approved by BRCGS and includes AOEC requirements.

Auditor training

Certification bodies shall develop a tailored training programme depending on the auditor's background.

Trainee auditors will have completed a significant number of relevant audits (>10 third-party audits which include HACCP, quality management systems, and good manufacturing practices in the previous two years).

Although the Global Standard Gluten-Free (Issue 4) Auditor training course allows those who successfully complete the course to audit against any product category as listed in Appendix 5, certification bodies shall be able to demonstrate that every auditor has appropriate training and experience for the particular categories in which they are considered competent.

Certification bodies are expected to have formal processes in place in which to assess and conclude the auditor's category competence. This shall include evaluation, methods may for example include:

- interview
- witness audit (in any relevant Standard)
- written examination which focuses on ensuring the auditor understands the technological requirements of the category in relation to the Global Standard Gluten-Free and can challenge the important control points for particular products and associated processes that fall into specific product categories.

The product category assessment shall be undertaken by a person who has knowledge and experience of each category that is assessed. Records shall be maintained of the competency assessment.

Full detailed training records of the individual shall be maintained by the certification body throughout the term of employment, and retained for a minimum period of five years after leaving the employment of the certification body.

Exceptions

Where a certification body employs an auditor who does not fully meet the specific criteria but has been assessed as competent, there shall be a fully documented justification in place to support the employment of the auditor which is agreed by BRCGS.

Responsibility of the certification body

It is the responsibility of the certification body to ensure that processes are in place to monitor and maintain the competence of the auditor to the level required by the Standard.

Appendix 5

Product categories

Field of audit	Category no.	Category description	Product examples
Raw products of animal or vegetable origin that require cooking prior to consumption	3	Raw prepared products (meat, poultry, fish, and vegetarian)	Bacon, comminuted meat and fish products (e.g. sausages, fish sticks), ready-to-cook meals, ready-prepared meat products, pizzas, vegetable prepared meals, steamer meals
Fruit, vegetables and nuts	6	Prepared fruit, vegetables, and nuts	Prepared/semi-processed fruit, vegetables and salads including prepared ready-to-eat salads, coleslaws, frozen vegetables
Processed foods and liquids with pasteurisation or UHT as heat treatment or similar technology	7	Dairy, liquid egg, pasteurised fruit juice	Liquid egg, liquid milk/drinks, cream, liquid tea and coffee creamers, yogurts, fermented milk-based products, fromage frais/crème fraîche, butter Ice cream Cheeses – hard, soft, mold-ripened, unpasteurised, processed cheese food Long-life milks, non-dairy products (e.g. soy milk), ambient yogurts, custards, etc. Fruit juices (includes freshly squeezed and pasteurised, smoothies) Dried whey powder, dried egg, dried milk/milk formulation
Processed foods, ready-to-eat or heat	8	Cooked meat/fish products	Cooked meats (e.g. ham, meat pâté, hot eating pies, cold eating pies), mollusks (ready to eat), crustaceans (ready to eat), fish pâté Hot smoked fish, poached salmon
	9	Raw cured and/or fermented meat and fish	Parma ham, ready-to-eat cold smoked fish, cured fish (e.g. gravlax), air-dried meats/salami, fermented meats, dried fish
Processed foods, ready-to-eat or heat	10	Ready meals and sandwiches, ready-to-eat desserts	Ready meals, sandwiches, soups, sauces, pasta, quiche, flans, meal accompaniments, cream cakes, trifles, assembled high-risk sweet desserts
Ambient stable products with pasteurisation or sterilisation as heat treatment	11	Low/high acid products in cans/glass	Canned or pouched products (e.g. beans, soups, meals, fruit, tuna); products packed in glass (e.g. sauces, jams, pickled vegetables) Pet food

Field of audit	Category no.	Category description	Product examples
Ambient stable products not involving sterilisation as heat treatment	12	Beverages	Soft drinks including flavoured water, isotonics, concentrates, squashes, cordials, minerals, table waters, ice, herbal drinks, food drinks
	13	Alcoholic drinks and fermented/brewed products	Beer, wine, spirits Vinegars Alcopops
	14	Bakery	Bread, pastry, cookies, cakes, tarts, breadcrumbs
	15	Dried products and ingredients	Soups, sauces, gravies, spices, stocks, herbs, seasonings, stuffings, pulses, legumes, rice, noodles, nut preparations, fruit preparations, dried pet food, vitamins, salt, additives, gelatin, glacé fruit, home baking, syrups, sugar, tea, instant coffee, and non-dairy coffee creamers
	16	Confectionery	Sugar confectionery, chocolate, gums and jellies, other candy
	17	Cereals and snacks	Oats, muesli, breakfast cereals, roasted nuts, crisps, poppadoms
	18	Oils and fats	Cooking oils, margarine, shortening, spreads, suet, ghee Salad dressings, mayonnaise, vinaigrettes
Cosmetics	19	Applies to the manufacture, storage, and transport of cosmetics	Includes powder, lotion, lipstick, or other preparations
Natural health products	20	Applies to the manufacture, blending, transport, and storage of natural health products	Includes natural health products (not dietary supplements; see category 21)
Manufacture of dietary supplements	21	Applies to the manufacture, blending, transport, and storage of dietary supplements	Includes vitamins, minerals, probiotics, and supplements
Manufacture of packaging materials	22	Applies to the manufacture, storage, and transport of food sector packaging materials	All packaging materials, including flexible films, paperboard-based containers, metal containers, flexible pouches, glass containers, plastic and foam containers (PET, polystyrene, etc.)

For the use of AOECS Crossed Grain Trademark please refer to Part II, section 8.

Appendix 6

Certificate template

Auditor number

CERTIFICATION BODY NAME OR LOGO

[CERTIFICATION BODY NAME, certification body number] certifies that, having conducted an audit

For the scope of activities:

Exclusions from scope:

Product categories:

AT COMPANY NAME

SITE CODE

AUDIT SITE ADDRESS

Meets the requirements set out in

GLOBAL STANDARD GLUTEN-FREE

ISSUE 4: FEBRUARY 2024

Including section 8 AOECs-specific requirements (delete as appropriate and update
exclusions from scope above)

Audit program: (e.g. standalone, combined)

Date(s) of audit:

Certificate issue date:

Re-audit due date: From To

Certificate expiry date:

Accreditation
body logo

Authorised by

BRCGS
logo

Name and full address of certification body

Certificate traceability reference

This certificate remains the property of [name of certification body]

If you would like to give feedback on the BRCGS Standard or the audit process directly to BRCGS,
please contact enquiries@brcgs.com or use the BRCGS reporting system at
<https://tellusbrcgs.whistleblownetwork.net>

To verify certificate validity, please visit <https://directory.brcgs.com>

Appendix 7

Corrective action, preventive action and root cause analysis

This appendix includes an example of a completed non-conformity summary sheet.

An important principle of the Standard is the need to ensure that actions are taken to address any failure in the food safety and quality management system. This is highlighted in several places within the Standard. There are two types of action recognised within the Standard:

- **Corrective action (sometimes referred to as correction)** Defined as action to eliminate a detected non-conformity or non-conforming product.
- **Preventive action** Defined as action to eliminate the fundamental underlying cause (root cause) of a detected non-conformity and prevent recurrence.

To identify the correct preventive action, it is necessary to complete root cause analysis, which is a problem-solving process for investigating an identified incident, non-conformity or situation. The aim of the root cause analysis is to enable the investigators to look beyond the solution to the immediate problem and understand the causes of the situation, so that the causes can be eliminated and therefore recurrence of the non-conformity or situation is prevented (preventive action).

For example, following a BRCGS audit, a site is required to complete corrective action, root cause analysis and preventive action for each of the non-conformities identified during the audit, and submit information demonstrating completion of these activities to its certification body. The final audit report will include details of each non-conformity, along with a summary of the corrective action taken and the proposed preventive action. (Preventive actions often take longer than 28 calendar days, and sites are therefore not expected to fully complete the preventive action prior to publication of the audit report.) A summary of the root cause analysis will also be included.

Table 2 is an example of a completed summary sheet from the audit report. It is worth noting that this is only a summary of the actions and analysis completed by the site, and does not include the full details that the site shares with the certification body.

Root cause analysis is not straightforward and can take time to identify why something occurred. BRCGS standards are not prescriptive in the methods by which root cause analyses are completed, and a number of tools exist. The simplest of these is the '5 Whys' technique, where the investigator continues to ask why or how something happened until the root cause procedure or process is identified.

Root cause analysis never seeks to blame an individual or group, even when human error may seem to be a contributory factor, but aims to consider why the error was made, and identify which process or procedure failed. The preventive action will then relate to a process or procedure that can be introduced or amended to stop the non-conformity recurring.

Examples of non-conformities, with poor-quality and acceptable root causes, as well as corrective and proposed preventive actions, are shown in Tables 3 and 4.

Table 2: An example of a completed non-conformity summary sheet from an audit report

MAJOR							
No.	Requirement ref.	Details of non-conformity	Corrective action	Proposed preventive action plan	Root cause analysis	Date reviewed	Reviewed by
1	6.1.3	The Schedule A for the site's own brand products does not accurately reflect trademark use.	The site will contact BRCGS to have the Schedule A renewed.	1) The Schedule A procedure shall be updated to include the need for re-approval when products are removed from the Schedule A. 2) Senior management will ensure the QA Manager is informed of the discontinuation of use of trademarks.	1) The Schedule A procedure only covered instances for re-approval where products were added, not removed. 2) Senior management did not inform the QA Manager of the discontinuation of two products which used a trademark.	1 Nov 2024	M. Oliver

Table 3: Summary of a root cause analysis (for failure to complete supplier approval audit)

Requirement	Non-conformity	Corrective action	Poor-quality root cause	Acceptable root cause	Proposed preventive action
3.4.4	The supplier approval audit for one supplier had not been completed. This is contrary to the site's supplier approval procedure.	Supplier approval audit completed 01 March 2024.	Travel embargo due to natural disaster prevented audit from being completed.	Travel embargo due to natural disaster prevented audit from being completed in 2023, and the alternative (temporary) supplier approval was not documented.	Ensure emergency procedures are fully documented, including details of minimum records and sign-off required.

In Table 3, there are two challenges associated with the poor-quality root cause analysis. Firstly, a natural disaster is not a manageable solution; it is outside the site's control and therefore the conclusion does not help the site to maintain the gluten-free status of its products. Secondly, the raw material was used by the site - therefore a member of staff approved its use using an undocumented mechanism. This cannot ensure compliance with either site processes or the Standard. The site can fix this by identifying in its procedures and records who is authorised to approve a raw material and the emergency process in the event of a situation preventing normal supplier approval.

Table 4: Summary of a root cause analysis (for failure to ensure packaging materials were removed from the line)

Requirement	Non-conformity	Corrective action	Poor-quality root cause	Acceptable root cause	Proposed preventive action
5.1.2	Packaging and labels from the previous production run were not removed from the line before product changeover.	Packaging materials for all products not in production were removed.	Production staff were unaware that the packaging materials were in the production area.	1) The appropriate documented checks were not carried out. 2) The procedure created for the documented checks did not identify a specific member of staff responsible.	The procedure will be updated to identify a specific member of staff, or position, on each shift who will be responsible for carrying out the documented checks.

Table 4 is an example of a root cause analysis that has identified staff error as a contributory factor associated with a non-conformity. In these situations, it is important to consider how the error could have occurred and therefore what process could be improved to make the error less likely.

BRCGS has published a full guideline document to help sites understand preventive action and root cause analysis, which includes tools for completing root cause analysis and some pitfalls to be avoided.

Appendix 8

Position statements

During the lifetime of the Standard, the BRCGS technical advisory committee (TAC; see Part IV) may be asked to:

- review the wording of a requirement in the Standard or protocol
- provide an interpretation for a requirement
- rule on the grading of a non-conformity against a specific clause.

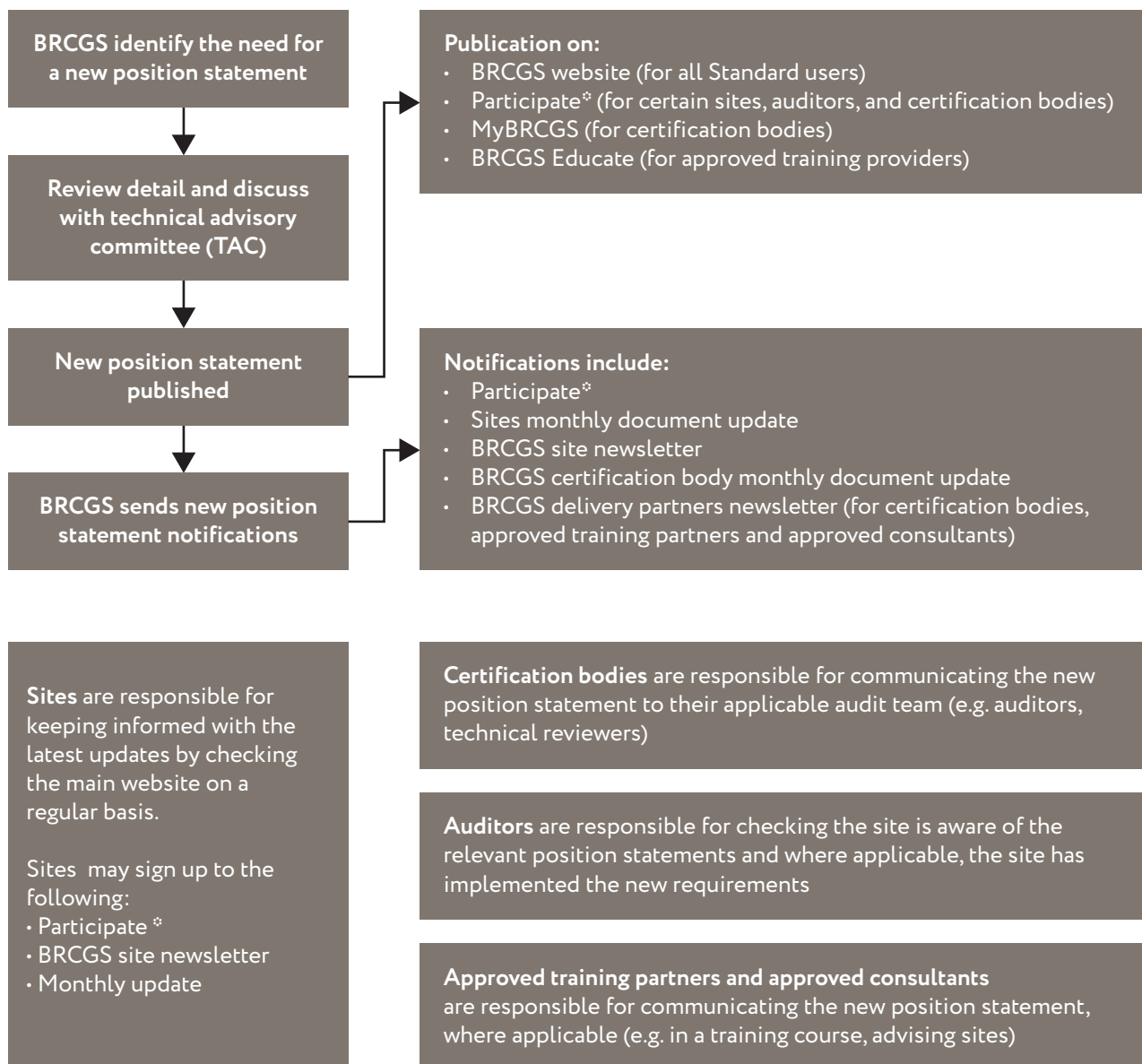
This outcome will be published on the BRCGS website as a 'position statement'. Position statements are binding on how the audit and certification process are carried out, and they are considered to be an extension of the Standard.

Companies shall be aware of any published position statements relating to the Standard and, where necessary, ensure that the information is transferred into action. Non-compliance with a relevant position statement may result in a non-conformity against clause 1.1.3.

Position statements are published on the BRCGS website and on Participate. They are also communicated electronically to companies and certification bodies (e.g. in bulletins and newsletters).

The process flow in Figure 3 below explains the communication process and responsibilities for certification bodies and sites when a new position statement is issued.

Figure 3: Position statement development and publication process



* Sites certificated to one of four BRCGS Standards - Agents & Brokers, Food Safety, Packaging Materials, Storage & Distribution - may sign up to Participate.

Appendix 9

Glossary

AOECS	The Association of European Coeliac Societies
AOECS member society	A non-profit organisation which represents in its own territory, directly or indirectly (e.g. by federating other local non-profit organizations or associations), people affected directly or indirectly by coeliac disease, dermatitis herpetiformis Duhring and other gluten related conditions. National Coeliac Societies can become full members or associate members of AOECS. They can adhere to the AOECS licensing system to manage the use of Crossed Grain Trademark in their territory.
AOECS registered products	Pre-packaged food products of a Licence Holder, identified by a Product Registration Number, which are produced and packaged meeting the requirements of the AOECS Standard.
Announced audit	An audit where the company agrees the scheduled audit day in advance with the certification body.
Annual/annually	Within 12 months since the action was last conducted.
Audit	A systematic examination to measure compliance of practices with a predetermined system, and whether the system is implemented effectively and is suitable to achieve objectives, carried out by certified bodies.
Auditor	A person possessing the appropriate competence and skills to carry out an audit.
Batch	The quantity of material prepared or required for one production operation.
Blended audit	An audit where the company agrees the scheduled audit day in advance with the certification body. • a remote audit of documents and records using ICT • an on-site audit concentrating on production, storage, good manufacturing practices and other on-site activities.
Brand owner	The owner of a brand logo or name who places the said logo or name onto retail products.
Brand Programme Agreement	Is the document signed by a product brand owner which provides the authorisation to use and apply the Global Standard Gluten-Free trademark(s) or similar words.
BRCGS-managed trademarks	Refers to the BRCGS Informed Gluten-Free, Beyond Celiac and Celiac Canada trademarks only. BRCGS does not manage the use of the ACELMEX or AOECS Crossed Grain Trademarks.
Calendar days	Calendar days are consecutive days, inclusive of Saturdays and Sundays.
Coeliac disease (also spelled celiac disease)	A serious autoimmune disorder that can occur in genetically predisposed people where the ingestion of gluten leads to damage in the small intestine, which can in turn lead to long-term health complications. See also non-coeliac gluten sensitivity
Certificate suspension	Revocation of certification for a given period, pending remedial action on the part of the company.

Certificate withdrawal	Where certification is revoked. Certification may only be regained following successful completion of the full audit process.
Certification	The procedure by which an accredited certification body, based on an audit and assessment of a company's competence, provides written assurance that a company conforms to a standard's requirements.
Certification body	Provider of certification services, accredited to do so by an authoritative body and registered with BRCGS.
Clause	A specific requirement or statement of intent that a site must comply with to achieve certification.
Cleaning	Cleaning is the process of achieving and maintaining an area to a standard deemed visually free from debris that can include dirt, food, faeces, blood, saliva and other bodily secretions. In other words, it is the removal of soil, food residues, dirt, grease and other objectionable matter.
Codex Alimentarius Commission	A body responsible for establishing internationally recognised standards, codes of practice and guidelines, of which HACCP (hazard analysis and critical control points) is one standard.
Company	The entity with legal ownership of the site which is being audited against a BRCGS Standard.
Competence	Demonstrable ability to apply skill, knowledge and understanding of a task or subject to achieve intended results.
Compliance	Meeting the regulatory or customer requirements concerning product safety, legality and quality.
Consultant	A company, organisation or individual that is subcontracted by the site to provide technical services relating to the gluten-free management system (for example, the development, implementation or maintenance of the gluten-free management system; the development or implementation of the HACCP plan; and the production of manuals or procedures).
Consumer	The end-user of the finished product, commodity or service.
Contamination	Introduction or occurrence of an unwanted organism, taint or substance to packaging, food, raw material or the food environment. Contamination includes physical, chemical, radiological, biological and allergen contamination.
Contractor or supplier	A person or organisation providing services or materials.
Control	To manage the conditions of an operation to maintain compliance with established criteria, and/or the state wherein correct procedures are being followed and criteria are being met.
Control measure	Any action or activity that can be used to prevent or eliminate a product safety hazard or reduce it to an acceptable level.
Controlled document	A document which is identifiable and for which revisions and removal from use can be tracked. The document is issued to specified individuals and their receipt of the document is recorded.
Consumer	The ultimate consumer of a foodstuff, who will not use the food as part of any food business operation or activity.

Corrective action (correction)	Action to eliminate a detected non-conformity or non-conforming product
Critical control point (CCP)	A step at which control can be applied and is essential to prevent or eliminate a food or product safety hazard or reduce it to an acceptable level.
Cross-contamination (cross-contact)	The transfer of any material from one surface or food to another. The terms 'cross-contact' and 'cross-contamination' are used interchangeably in guidance about allergen management.
Crossed Grain Trademark	A registered trademark, managed by the AOECs and its members, which enables consumers, particularly people with coeliac disease, dermatitis herpetiformis Duhning or other gluten related conditions, to identify safe gluten-free foods. It can be used in pre-packaged food products as defined in the Licence Contract between the Licence Holder and the National Coeliac Societies and related guidelines.
Customer	A business or person to whom a service or product has been provided, either as a finished product or as a component part of the finished product.
Dispatch	The point at which the product leaves the factory site or is no longer the responsibility of the company.
Disinfection	Disinfection is the process or act of destroying pathogenic micro-organisms; it removes most organisms present on surfaces.
Distribution	The transportation of goods within any container (goods on the move) by road, rail, air or ship.
Drug	As defined by the national, regulatory competent authority where the product is sold.
Flow diagram	A systematic representation of the sequence of steps or operations used in the production or manufacture of a particular food item.
Food	As defined by the national, regulatory competent authority where the product is sold.
Food additive	As defined by the national, regulatory competent authority where the product is sold.
Food business operator	The persons responsible for ensuring that the legal food law requirements are met within the food business under their control, and includes food manufacturers, processors, wholesalers, distributors, importers, exporters and retailers.
Food safety	Assurance that food will not cause harm to the consumer when it is prepared and/or eaten according to its intended use.
Global Food Safety Initiative (GFSI)	Managed by the Consumer Goods Forum, a project to harmonise and benchmark international food safety standards (www.mygfsi.com).
Good manufacturing practice (GMP)	Implemented procedures and practices undertaken using best-practice principles.
Gluten	A protein fraction (e.g. gliadins or glutenins) from wheat, rye, barley, oats ² or their crossbred varieties and derivatives thereof, to which some persons are intolerant and that is insoluble in water and 0.5M sodium chloride.

² Does not include verifiable gluten-free oats.

Gluten-free management system	The result of a Hazard Analysis and Critical Control Points (HACCP) assessment that is prepared in accordance with the requirements of the BRCGS Global Standard Gluten-Free for a process or product and that specifies, in respect of the process or product, all the hazards, critical control points, critical limits, monitoring procedures, deviation procedures, verification procedures, and records.
Gluten-free product	Any product that conforms to the requirements of the BRCGS Global Standard Gluten-Free.
Hazard Analysis and Critical Control Point (HACCP)	A system that identifies, evaluates and controls hazards which are significant for food safety.
Hazard	A biological, chemical or physical agent or factor that has the potential to cause a product to be unsafe for human consumption or a failure to conform to the Global Standard Gluten-Free in the absence of its control.
Ingredient	is an individual unit of product that is combined with one or more other individual units of a product formulation to form an integral unit of product.
Initial audit	The audit for certification to a BRCGS Standard at a company or site that is not in possession of a valid certificate. This may be the first audit at a site or a subsequent audit of a site whose certification has lapsed.
Input	A material which is not an ingredient but is, however, required to complete the manufacture of the product (e.g. processing aids, packaging, cleaning materials) and may contribute to gluten contamination of the product.
Inspection	Targeted verification (often a visual check against a 'tick list' for fabrication, environment and equipment) to ensure operation to safe expected levels.
Internal audit	General process of audit, for all the activity of the company. Conducted by or on behalf of the company for internal purposes.
Label	Any tag, mark, picture or other descriptive matter, whether it is written, printed or otherwise marked, on or attached to the packaging of the product. Where a product is unlabelled, specifications or information to meet legal requirements and to assist customers in the safe usage of the product shall be maintained, and are included in the definition of a label
Labelling	Any words, picture or symbol relating to the food and placed on any packaging or label accompanying the product.
List of certificated sites	The list of companies maintained by BRCGS deemed to be in conformance with the Global Standard Gluten-Free.
Manufacturer	A company that produces product from raw materials and/or components and packs the product or supplies product in bulk. A packer that packs product into retail units from bulk-supplied material can also be classed as a manufacturer.
May	Indicates a requirement or text which provides guidance but is not mandatory for compliance with the Standard.
Matrix	All components of a sample, with the exception of the analyte of interest (in this case, gluten) that can affect the testing result.

Monitoring	A planned sequence of observations or measurements of defined control parameters to assess whether predefined limits are being met.
Non-coeliac gluten sensitivity	A condition with gastrointestinal and/or extraintestinal symptoms that is triggered by gluten ingestion in the absence of coeliac disease and wheat allergy.
Non-conformity	The non-fulfilment of a specified product safety, legal or quality requirement or a specified system requirement.
Online verification equipment	Automated equipment (e.g. barcode scanners) that are used to check the accuracy or quality of product labels and printing.
Outsourced processing (subcontracted processing)	Outsourced processing (also referred to as subcontracted processing) is when intermediate production, processing, storage or a step in the manufacture of a product is completed at another company or site. Outsourced processing is an intermediate step; therefore during outsourced processing, the product or partly processed product leaves the site being audited for the completion of the outsourced processing before returning to the site. The audited site may or may not complete the additional packing or processing steps of the product. Where raw materials receive additional storage or processing prior to their arrival on site, this is not considered to be outsourced processing, but should be managed by the site using supplier approval mechanisms, raw material risk assessments and raw material specifications. When a product leaves the site and does not return, this is not outsourced processing; the activities completed off site are outside the scope of the audit.
Ownership (change of company ownership)	A change of ownership occurs when the title is transferred from one individual or entity to another and results in a change of control of the organisation.
Position statement	Where clarification of the interpretation of a requirement of a BRCGS Standard or its protocol is necessary, this will be published on the BRCGS website as a position statement. Such statements are binding on the way that the audit and certification process are carried out and are considered to be an extension of the Standard. They are applicable from the date specified for implementation (or the date of publication on the BRCGS website, where no date is specified).
Premises	A physical building or place owned by the company and audited as part of a site.
Prerequisite	The basic environmental and operational conditions in a food business that are necessary for the production of safe food. These control generic hazards covering good manufacturing and hygiene practices, and form a foundation for the food safety or HACCP plan. Prerequisites shall be considered as part of that plan.
Preventive action	Action to eliminate the fundamental underlying cause (root cause) of a detected non-conformity and prevent recurrence.
Procedure	Agreed method of carrying out an activity or process which is implemented and documented in the form of detailed instructions or process description (e.g. a flowchart).
Product recall	Any measures aimed at achieving the removal of an unfit (e.g. unsafe) product from customers and final consumers.

Product withdrawal	Any measures aimed at achieving the removal of out-of-specification or unfit (e.g. unsafe) products from customers, but not from final consumers. A withdrawal is normally used to remove product where there is no risk to consumers; for example, where the product has not reached the point of sale to consumers.
Quantity check/mass balance	A reconciliation of the amount of incoming ingredients or inputs against the amount used in the resulting finished products, which also takes into account process waste and rework.
Requirement	Those statements comprising a clause with which compliance will allow sites to be certificated.
Retailer	A business selling products to the public by retail.
Risk	The likelihood of occurrence of harm from a hazard.
Risk analysis	A process consisting of three components: risk assessment, risk management and risk communication.
Risk assessment	The identification, evaluation and estimation of the levels of risk involved in a process to determine an appropriate control process.
Root cause(s)	The underlying cause(s) of a problem, which, if adequately addressed, will prevent a recurrence of that problem.
Sampling plan	A documented plan defining the number of samples to be selected, the acceptance or rejection criteria and the statistical confidence of the result.
Sanitation	Sanitation means to adequately treat cleaned surfaces by a process that is effective in destroying the vegetative cells of pathogens, and in substantially reducing the numbers of other undesirable micro-organisms, but without adversely affecting the product or its safety for the consumer.
Schedule	A tabulated statement giving details of actions and/or timings.
Schedule A	A control and tracking document, listing the gluten-free products produced at a site which are intended to display BRCGS-managed trademarks and/or the ACELMEX trademark.
Seasonal production site	A site that is opened for a short duration (typically 12 weeks or less) during a 12-month cycle; for example, to specifically harvest and process a product. Details of the additional considerations for the management of the audit and certification process for seasonal production sites are given in Part III, section 3.7.8.
Senior management	Person or group of people who direct and control an organisation at the highest level. Note that top (senior) management has the power to delegate authority and provide resources within the organisation.
Shall	Signifies a requirement to comply with the contents of the clause.
Site	A unit of a company; the entity which is audited and which is the subject of the audit report and certificate.
Site Programme Agreement	The official document a site is required to sign prior to gaining certification. The document is a formal contract between BRCGS and the site and outlines the fee structure and terms and conditions of certification to the Global Standard Gluten-Free.

Specification	An explicit or detailed description of a material, product or service.
Specifier	A company or person requesting the product or service.
Standard, the	The Global Standard Gluten-Free (Issue 4).
Supplier	The person, firm, company or other entity to which a site's purchase order to supply is addressed.
Traceability	Ability to trace and follow ingredients, inputs and products, through all stages of receipt, production, processing and distribution both forwards and backwards.
Trademarked product	Products bearing a gluten-free trademark of BRCGS, or a coeliac/ceciac association included in scope of the Standard.
Unannounced audit	An audit undertaken on a date unknown to the company in advance.
Universal Product Code (UPC)	A unique 12-digit number assigned to each individual product sold in stores and online. It is used to identify and track products as they are sold, shipped, and received. The UPC is also used in inventory control and as a means of price comparison.
Validation	Obtaining evidence through the provision of objective evidence that a control or measure, if properly implemented, is capable of delivering the specified outcome.
Verification	The application of methods, procedures, tests and other evaluations, in addition to monitoring, to determine whether a control or measure is or has been operating as intended.
Where appropriate	In relation to a requirement of the Standard, the company will assess the need for the requirement and, where applicable, put in place systems, processes, procedures or equipment to meet the requirement. The company shall be mindful of legal requirements, best-practice standards, good manufacturing practice and industry guidance, and any other information relating to the manufacture of safe and legal product.
Work in progress/work in process	Partially manufactured products, intermediates or materials waiting for completion of the manufacturing process.
Working day	A day on which work is usually or routinely done at the site.

Appendix 10

Participate

Participate is a document information management system that allows BRCGS to deploy the content from its full range of standards, guidelines and additional modules through digital channels. It is a managed online service that certificated sites can access to view content, download PDFs, watch webinars and have discussions with peers. Registered sites can access BRCGS Standards and other supporting documents across many devices.

Participate features include:

- multi-lingual content
- searchable content
- a library to save content for easy access in the future
- a monthly newsletter listing updated content
- 24/7 worldwide access on web-enabled devices using a secure password system.

To learn more, please visit lgcassure.com/participate.

BRCGS publishes additional guidance on topics covered by requirements within other BRCGS Standards. Sites certificated to any one of four BRCGS standards, (Agents & Brokers, Food Safety, Packaging Materials, Storage & Distribution) can download this guidance for free from Participate. Alternatively, copies can be purchased from the BRCGS Store. Topics include:

- air quality
- allergen management
- cleaning of workwear
- environmental monitoring
- fresh produce
- production risk zones
- internal audit
- lighting
- lubrication
- pest management
- preventive action and root cause analysis
- product changeover
- product recall
- product safety culture
- raw poultry
- raw red meat
- vulnerability assessments.

Appendix 11

Acknowledgements

BRCGS is grateful to the members of the working groups who helped to develop Issue 4 of the Global Standard Gluten-Free. Their names are listed alphabetically below.

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